

Heartbeat Passage

Written by Arian Mabe (Amethyst Mare)

Christian walked without rhyme or reason to his footsteps, striding between the coniferous trees as the forest enveloped him. There was no path to follow, only loam that was rarely trodden by human beings in its isolation and a quiet peace that chased the ache of study from his mind. Spring sang through the forest, a harmonious melody of birdsong as the culprits flitted from branch to branch, and he lost himself in their instrumental language, sinking into a world that he feared, one day, mankind would forget. From his flat, it was only a short walk before he reached the tree line of the woods and, from there on out, he could forget the human world completely, losing himself in a natural, unspoilt world.

He scratched his head, fingers raking through a mop of brown hair already tousled from a light wind. It never seemed worth the effort that others of his age went to in styling it, though it was the fashion of the younger generation to be glued up with hair gel. He had no idea how people had the time to think about their appearance when there was so much to do, so much studying. University was gruelling. Christian shook his head, shoving his hands deep into the pockets of his olive green jacket, which was light enough to keep the spring chill from his skin. He'd had the jacket for several years but, even though the zip caught, he looked after his belongings so well that everyone not in the know thought that he'd bought it only a few days before wearing it out.

Mind wandering, he rolled his shoulders, his studies tickling at the back of his mind. They never truly went away, always prying when he wanted a little escape for himself. He'd come to the end of his engineering degree and, while he found it interesting, the working world loomed ahead with gaping jaws, threatening in the unknown. Maybe that was why he spent so much time walking in the forest as it meant he did not have to face a truth that he didn't yet know how to tackle. Of course, life would sweep him along when the time came and he would not be alone in the first steps of his career but Christian dove into books with greater relish than ever before, living another life and only returning to the real world when it demanded he do so.

Sometimes it was better to live in a fantasy world. Yet reality would always have a loving hold to guide him back to the present, his friends and family. Christian's lips tugged up in an unconscious smile. He should go see his mother sometime soon. She must be missing him – she often called him to see how his work was going. It was a shame that he never really had all that much to say. Life continued on much the same as it had done before. What new was there anymore?

He paused at a small clearing, head tilted back to a blue sky dotted with wisps of clouds high, high above. He shifted, rubbed his thigh and wriggled his hand back into his pocket again, hiding it from view. Although the birds sang as merrily as ever and a red squirrel scampered along a thick branch in a flick of bushy tail, something held him in place, heartbeat quickening. The skin on the back of his neck prickled and he stood perfectly still, listening as intently as a human could, which was not all that intently when it came right down to it.

Was he not alone in the forest? Christian swallowed, Adam's apple bobbing sluggishly as his throat grew tight.

The squirrel brushed past leaves as it darted away, streaking higher into the pines, and he struggled to discern any noise that could be from a silent watcher. Did they mean to harm him? Was there even anyone there? Were they animal or human? Christian narrowed his eyes, peering through slanted sunlight, suddenly too bright and glaring in his eyes when he needed to see all he could.

He turned in a slow circle, three hundred and sixty degrees, skin cooling. There couldn't be anyone there, surely not. It was his imagination running away with him. Christian relaxed, hands uncurling from fists he had not realised had formed in his pockets. How daft he could be!

"It is strange to see one of your kind so far from buildings of concrete and brick."

He jumped, look back over his left shoulder and then his right when the owner of the voice was not immediately forthcoming. His heart beat frantically and, though the voice did not *seem* threatening, he brought his hands out of his pockets, at the ready, in case they were needed. Christian could have laughed at himself. Just what did he think he was actually going to do if he was attacked? Hit his assailant with a book? He felt the weight of his small backpack, straps across both shoulders. Well, it could work.

A feminine giggle, not unlike the nicker of an equine, burbled up from the flora adorning a thicket, trees growing close enough that a large creature could hide itself inside and never be found by the casual hiker.

"Forgive me. I do not mean to jest so. I would not remain hidden from you, Christian."

Between two pines trees, their arms outstretched, the bushes rustled, rounded leaves drifting to the ground as they were disturbed from their branches, and he took a step back, hands raised apprehensively. Yet what – or who – emerged from concealment surprised him more than any predator with ill intentions could ever have. A unicorn, as bold as the light of day, stepped out of a thicket as if she was part of the luscious undergrowth herself, her coat as white as freshly fallen snow on the mountain. A spiralled, silver horn rose fluidly from the centre of her forehead and her long, flowing mane and tail fell down over the arch of her neck and powerful hindquarters like the finest of spun silk.

Christian gaped, closing his jaw quickly when he realised he was staring. But how was he *not* supposed to stare at a unicorn? She – for she was certainly a female from the lilt in her voice and defined, dished face – pawed lightly at the earth, a golden, woven bracelet jingling musically as precious gems tickled one another upon her leg. The bracelet, stretching from the knee of her right foreleg down to her fetlock, was not the only piece of jewellery she wore. Around her neck hung a visually heavy circlet of gold, sliced through with crimson and emerald shades so pure that Christian could only suspect that they were the finest cuts of the stones found naturally. The necklace dipped down to a 'V' over her chest, the very heart of it cupping a milky opal that flickered with every colour under the sun as the unicorn moved, the very movement of her breath changing the beautiful into the exquisite.

She raised her head, taller than the human, to look at him from the side with one, intelligent eye. Christian shivered. Violet was not a natural colour for such an orb, yet it sat perfectly upon her head, crafted for her, as unique as she was.

“I’ve been watching you for some time.” The unicorn said with a gentle toss of her head, flipping her mane over to the other side of her neck. “You are quite the fascinating human, Christian.”

He started, blinking foolishly as words flourished and died on his tongue.

“You’ve been following me?” He forced out after a longer pause than he was proud of. “For how long? Not from the flat, surely not? How could I have not seen you?”

“Oh...” She ducked her head, forelock falling over her eyes as she peeked up with a look that was both shy and decidedly mischievous. “It’s been a little longer than that. And only when you entered the forest, mostly then. I’m too easy to spot within your city, hardly easy to trot around when humans are gawping at you like you’ve grown a second head. But you like to walk here and read here rather a lot, don’t you?”

“How long...” He shook his head, bringing his hands up behind his neck, fingers splaying flat against skin. “How long have you been watching me, if it has been more than today? And why on earth? I didn’t even know unicorns lived so close to the cities. I thought you hated the cities.”

Despite his shock at being stalked and then addressed by a creature so often assigned to myth and legend, excitement stirring in his chest like butterflies trapped behind the birdcage of his ribs. What was her life like? How long had she been living in the forest, meandering so close to his home? *Where* did she live? Why had such a beautiful – there was no denying her elegant grace – unicorn decided to reveal herself to him? Christian grinned like a loon, his smile widening without conscious thought.

And why on earth was she following him through the forest? More than once!

The unicorn turned her body side on to him, jaw working as she licked her lips with a broad, fleshy tongue – a sliver of pink.

“I am Celeste,” she introduced herself, tail swishing. “And you already are aware that I know who you are.”

“That’s...certainly a lovely name,” he said lamely, struggling to come up with better words. “And one befitting your splendour. But how do you know who I am?”

“I have followed you into the city sometimes, though it is more difficult to blend in. Most humans think me a dumb equine, not a being of their intelligence. It can be funny sometimes. I take some amusement from them. Yet, kind Christian, there is a reason that I have revealed myself to you today that is not satisfied by jest and small talk.”

“Oh? Why now of all times?” The young man shook his head, a strange laugh that was not amusement bubbling up to his lips. “I... Well... I can’t be all that interesting to you. You’re a unicorn.”

“Yes, I am a unicorn.”

Celeste tilted her head, silver hoof resting on its tip upon the grass.

“Why would that be an answer to you not being interesting?”

Celeste rocked her head from side to side, horn sparkling in the sunlight.

“You are interesting to me because you are a human. And you are yet so different from the other humans I’ve seen!”

Life burst to her hooves and she pirouetted on her hind legs, hooves pawing the air as the wind caught her mane to trail it out from the side away from her neck. Christian followed her every move, eyes riveted upon her body. Had there ever been a creature so purely majestic?

“Christian, in all my years, I have never found another being as fascinating to me as I find you.” She dropped back to all four hooves, neck arched. “You’re a different being. There’s a light in you, Christian. I can’t help but want to know more. And I will know more. That’s if, you will allow me closer to you, into part of *your* world.”

Celeste smiled with her eyes, lips tugged up in a fraction that was her version of a smile; her equine muzzle did not allow for overtly human facial expressions, yet she made do. Turning away, Christian struggled for words, starting a sentence several times only to let it trail off into nothingness as the unicorn nickered encouragingly, patiently waiting for him to come around.

“I am very flattered that you think I’m fascinating...” He blushed, rubbing the back of his neck as he slid his gaze away, cheeks too warm for comfort. “It’s not something I never would’ve thought about myself. You are by far the more interesting individual here, I must say.”

“Then we both are interested by one another.”

Celeste paused, horn angled expectantly towards him. He would have spoke in the silence but held his tongue, feeling that something hung in the air between them that she was gearing up to say.

“Christian...” She raised a front hoof, bobbing it in the air. “Would you be so kind as to accompany me on a date?”

Christian stared at her blankly. He must have misheard. He chuckled and rubbed his arm, shifting his weight back on to his heels.

“A date?”

He did his best to keep his jaw from falling slack, sure that Celeste was going to correct him at any given moment. The unicorn whinnied, head tossing back as her mane fell in time to shimmer down her neck, every part of her body perfectly in tune. The young man shifted uncomfortably, unable to find a comfortable position in which to stand – nothing seemed right. Something twisted inside him. Oh, if only he was wrong... If only she *had* actually invited him on a date. That would have made everything so much better, truly, as insane and crazy as the notion was.

“Yes, a date.” Her violet eyes twinkled. “Is that not what humans call courtship these days?”

“Uhh... Yes?”

“Then the term is correct!”

Celeste lifted both front hooves a few inches off the ground as she pranced, head bobbing in what Christian could only assume was unicorn excitement, dancing as human would on the balls of their feet. He hadn’t spent all that much time around equines in the past. It seemed that that was about to change.

“Is that a yes?” She pressed, insistent on an answer. “You will go on a date with me, will you not, Christian?”

“Well... H-how could I say no?” Christian stammered, tongue-tied and twisting his fingers together. “Of course it’s a yes! Though I can’t believe *you* have asked me. It’s hard to take in, I hope that’s okay.” He rubbed his forehead, brow furrowed, pain flaring in his temple. “I fear this is all a dream I’m going to wake up from. You have to admit that this is all a bit surreal...Celeste.”

He liked how her name sounded on his tongue. Celeste whinnied, dipping her shapely head.

“Excellent! I believe it is customary for the male to divine the venue of the date.”

He swore her eye twinkled but she swept the flicker away beneath her forelock.

“Christian, where may I meet you for our date? Is there a common location that you can suggest?”

Shaking his head, he wondered what he was getting into but ploughed ahead regardless, reckless as anticipation tickled his nerves.

“By the edge of the forest would be easy for both of us to get to, I think. Are you familiar with the monument? The statue of a man riding a horse and the list of names?”

For the first time, Celeste appeared sheepish and dragged the toe of her hoof through the dirt, drawing mindless circles with the tip as she hid behind her forelock.

“Only for all the times I’ve followed you, Christian. I would be free come the end of the week, your weekend, if you are also available to meet.” She ducked her head. “If my observations are correct, you do not have lectures to attend come Saturday. Would that be convenient for you?”

He chuckled, relieved to have the arrangements sorted, the technicalities of meeting smoothing themselves out as they conferred.

“Saturday at noon it is then.”

As the unicorn melted into the trees with no more than a whisper of leaves to denote her presence, Christian stood stock still, eyes taking on a dreamy cast. She moved so beautifully as if she was floating over the earth rather than pacing over it, each stride perfection exhibited. Who else could say that they had a date with such a physically and intellectually intelligent lady?

Although, as his heart swelled and fluttered, he knew he had a date to plan. And it had to be the best date he would ever come up with in his lifetime.

No pressure then.

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“Christian. People are *staring*.”

Walking along one of the side streets with a unicorn was not the most subtle of moves, Christian lamented to himself, though refused to articulate the thought aloud. They only had to get through part of the town and all would be fine – they’d be at the place he’d planned for their date, with what little information he knew about Celeste. Oh god, how he hoped it would go off without a hitch! Garbed in turquoise jewellery and a headpiece that hooked over her ears to drape the semi-precious stones down the sides of her face, she appeared goddess-like in her grace, even if shying away from curious onlookers. They had, undoubtedly, never seen the likes of a unicorn before. He couldn’t blame them: he’d done the same.

“I think it’s expected for them to stare.” He frowned, lips turning down. “You are a unicorn, after all. Please, try not to pay any attention to them. They won’t do anything to you, I promise.”

Celeste lifted her head, ears pricked and alert as a car tootled past, slowing to almost a crawl as its occupants gawked. One girl with pigtails held up a mobile phone to take a picture of the unicorn. Celeste snorted and lifted a back hoof, tail swishing.

“I don’t think it’s solely because of that.”

Her expression was troubled and she turned her shoulder to a group of young men with slack jaws, pointing rudely as her shimmering form glided smoothly past in a clip of polished hooves.

“Come now.” Christian smiled and touched her shoulder lightly with his fingertips as they continued on, muscle moving beneath a taut, smooth coat. “I have somewhere quieter for us to go, somewhere more peaceful than this crowd. It’ll be okay, you’ll see.”

He didn’t know where his sudden burst of confidence had come from but he had to believe in himself. Heart pounding like a runaway steam train of olden times, Christian led the way through the streets, heading to a spot that was in the heart of the city and not at the same time. Whereas the library was easily accessible, few people used it these days and much fewer the archive library.

And his unicorn had a love of literature.

Leading her down a side street, he rapped on the back entrance of the library with his knuckles, dropping his other hand to his pocket to make sure his phone was there. If Damien didn't answer, he'd only have to give him a ring. In the dimmer light of the side street with tall town houses and offices reaching towards the sky, Celeste exhaled softly, peering over Christian's shoulder with great curiosity.

"What are you doing? Why are we here?"

"You'll see." He laughed lightly as her head poked over his shoulder, warm breath washing over his cheek. "Patience, patience!"

"I have *plenty* of patience," she snorted, tapping the side of his head with her horn – gentle enough to be playful. "The difference is that impatience is ruling right now. Let's go inside!"

"We have to wait to be let in, Celeste – ah, here he is!"

Christian grinned as a key turned in a lock on the other side of the door and he stepped forward to greet a small, middle-aged man that appeared permanently hunched over and shrunk into himself. The man squinted up at them through a pair of round spectacles, blonde hair cropped economically short to his skull. There was a zit perched contentedly on the end of his pointed nose.

"Good afternoon, Christian," the man said, stepping back to allow them inside with barely a second glance at Celeste. "It's nice to see you back. Do come in – and quickly now. You'll let the warm out."

Stepping inside to a long corridor, the librarian closed the door at their heels and led them deeper into the bowels of the building. Celeste took shorter strides to keep a more comfortable pace while Christian made his introductions.

"Celeste, this is Damien. He manages the library here. He spends most of his time down the archives so you don't see much of him."

"Yes, well, I have to take care of the books, all climate controlled. My reading pleasures are best enjoyed in peace and quiet too, not the rough housing of this city. That reading in coffee shops lark will never sit right with you. You know that. I've said it before. A pleasure to meet you, my lady," he added, directing the last part of his utterance at Celeste.

"A pleasure to meet you too, sir."

"It's only usually me back here, I do so hope you'll forgive the dust." He waved a hand, a wedding band on the fourth finger. "This isn't as important to keep clear. The books are more important."

He took them to the brightness of an open lobby and respite area, dotted with comfortable sofas and various other seating for avid readers to situate themselves upon. Stairs rose from this lowered, reading section to the main event of the bookshelves, which stretched back further and further, packed to the brim, until their stature secluded them from eyesight. Celeste looked from left to right and up to the ceiling, adorned with an imitation of a rare

tapestry, in awe. Christian hid his smile. If she had been human, her jaw would have dropped as much as his had when he had first seen the unicorn.

Damien cleared his throat softly.

“If you do that way,” he inclined his head to the bookshelves, illuminated by gentle overhead lighting strips, “you’ll have access to the complete public library. However, if you follow me, you’ll see a collection that only some are privileged enough to access.”

Celeste dragged her gaze away from the books with great difficulty, eyes filled with longing.

“My village doesn’t have so many tomes! However did you acquire them all?” She paused, mind catching up with Damien’s words. “What do you mean there are more? More scrolls to be uncovered?” She stamped a hoof. “Where? Show me!”

Damien fluttered his fingers as Celeste trotted into the lobby, pivoting in the midst of a ring of plush sofas to take in her surroundings. A teenage girl blinked at the unicorn, tugged at her plait and returned to her hardback book, only pausing to tuck herself more securely into the crook of the sofa. Her roll of the shoulders bolstered Christian. Maybe not everyone was so in awe of a unicorn that they would gape like goldfish and make his date uncomfortable. He pushed his hair back, trying to tame the wayward strands into something more acceptable of style with his fingertips. No matter, either way – where they were going, they would have no company but each other, exactly as he’d planned.

As Celeste moved in the direction in which Damien had gestured for more wonders, he brought a hand to his face and shuffled from foot to foot.

“Ah, but the hooves...”

“I shall tread very carefully,” Celeste rushed to reassure him, craning her head back round to peer between the shelves. “How many books do you have here?”

“In the archive?” The librarian blinked, pushing his glasses back up his nose. “Three hundred thousand on my last count. This is the largest archive library in the country.”

His tone rang with pride and, as they were permitted into the locked archive section of the library, she inundated the librarian with questions, commanding his attention. If Christian had had any doubt about her intelligence – he knew so little about unicorns at all – her sharp queries assuaged that concern within the course of a few minutes.

So far reassured that Celeste would treat his charges with care, Damien took them to the library, squeezing the unicorn mare down a narrow corridor that opened up into a reading room. Ever the hospitable host, he granted them access to a comfortable, plush bean bag for Celeste – clearly thought out in advance – and a straight backed but padded reading chair for Christian. The edge of the room had a few bookcases for tomes that were less sensitive to sunlight while the left side of the room as they walked in was floor to ceiling glass, looking out over the city and scurrying life. Celeste nickered, stretching out her head to touch the glass with her velvety nose.

“This is amazing... Do all of your cities have collections like this?”

Christian smiled.

“Only the very best. The books are through here.” He inclined his head towards a second door, closed with a key in the lock. “Most of them need to be kept in a climate controlled environment, out of direct sunlight.”

Damien nodded his agreement, fiddling with his glasses.

“Please, help yourself to anything from the archive. I must return to the library but Christian well enough knows his way around.” Damien smiled, retreating backwards towards the door. “He can be your guide.”

“And I am confident he will excel at it.”

Christian blushed and tried to surreptitiously rub the blush from his cheeks as Celeste turned her attention to him, Damien retreating politely from the reading room. Clearing his throat, he smiled at the unicorn, lips rubbery and gestures ungainly as he struggled in the glow of her beauty. Her look was devastating, violet eyes capturing and drawing him in and in and in. He blinked and shook his head as if to clear it.

“What would you like to retrieve from the archives? Is there anything in particular that you are interested in?”

Celeste considered, horn angled to the side.

“Do you have anything along the lines of historical accounts? Great battles along our shores? I have heard of some landings but my knowledge of specific human history has gaps.”

“Of course.” Christian gestured to her to follow. “I know exactly where those are.”

Diving into the archives, he stepped into rows upon rows of books with a sense of calm familiarity. The air was cool and tickled their skin as they paced within, Celeste with her ears pricked and unsure of which direction in which to look. So many tomes! How could she ever spend enough time in such a library to read them all? She nickered and Christian smiled at her eagerness, selecting a few choice hardbacks for her with yellowing pages. In a past life, before being donated to the archive, they had not been as well cared for.

She didn’t allow them to return to the reading room but insisted they pour over them right there in the archives themselves. Finding a small table, Christian gently heaved one up for her perusal, opening it to the title page. The cover was dark brown leather, engraved and painted with gold leaf to highlight the exquisite detailing. There he was faced with an issue: how would she turn the pages? He watched in awe as her horn took on a light glow, a silver shimmer so subtle that he could have missed it if not peering closely, aiding her in turning the pages.

If unicorns existed...it made sense that magic did too. Christian swallowed hard, suddenly feeling very small and insignificant. Why had a magical being asked him out on a date? Could he measure up? There was only one way to tell and he was as interested in history as the unicorn.

Leaning in close to Celeste, he basked in the warmth of her. After what seemed like an age – he was sure the light was growing dim outside – the unicorn sighed and raised her head, shaking out the kinks from holding her neck arched in one position for so long. She started, one hoof catching the floor and nudged Christian’s shoulder with a guilty shine to her eye, muzzle bobbing.

“Christian!” She spoke as if she had forgotten he had been by her side through her engrossment in the records. “I’m sorry, I’m being a terrible companion. It’s only...”

She turned in a slow circle, careful of her hindquarters as she took in as much of the archives as was possible, gaze yearning and hungry for the knowledge contained within.

“I completely understand,” Christian said warmly. “I was exactly the same the first time I came down here. We’re lucky to have a library like this to use.”

Celeste brushed his cheek with her nose and his heart jumped in his chest, thudding so loudly that he was afraid she would hear, she had to hear it! He covered up his nerves by finding a piece of literature purely for himself and encouraging the unicorn back to the reading room where they would be more comfortable. Celeste giggled as he walked backwards, fingers as crooked as his lopsided smile. Her eyes shone and there was a spring in her light, easy step.

Sitting down with an early edition – first run – of Stubb’s Anatomy of the Horse, Christian turned the pages absent-mindedly, tracing his fingers over the images, a curious combination of etching and inking that he had never quite been able to figure out.

“So, Celeste,” he began, a little formally, “tell me about yourself. What is your home and your family like?”

She settled herself on top of the red bean bag sofa before replying, head over the table where a book on myths and legends, penned by a name she had never heard, rested for her approval.

“I live several league or so from where we met in the forest, earlier this week. It is one of the deepest parts of the forest. It is not intended to be out of the way of mankind but it has that effect.”

Celeste wrinkled her nose, snorting daintily.

“Humans are better away from our kind, mostly, and the majority are more infatuated with their cities rather than the natural world around them. Some parts are still untouched with many creatures roaming wild, living away from concrete walls.”

“I understand, being in the city never sat right with me,” Christian confessed. “It seems so closed in and I can’t sit for very long, unless I’m reading.” He chuckled, fingering the page. “That’s a different story.”

“I can understand why you stayed in a city when you have a *library* like this.”

“Don’t you have libraries with your herd and your home?”

Celeste tilted her head from side to side: *sort of*.

“We have scrolls recording our history but our stories are passed down in the spoken word, generation by generation. Seeing how your kind have recorded even tales makes me wonder if we should have taken greater steps to document what may be lost.”

“It’s never too late to start.” Christian paused, mulling her words over. “But what do mean about something being lost?”

Celeste sighed, muzzle dipping down to the table as her ears drooped, slanting to the sides of her head.

“Life is...difficult for the herd at this time. Life is not what it once was for us.”

She blinked, throat working as she swallowed. Christian trailed his fingers over her mane lightly, waiting for her to continue while offering what comfort he could. Did she mind him touching her? Her skin was electric beneath his fingertips and he inhaled sharply when she leaned into his touch, eyes half closed as she nickered softly.

“We are struggling to survive with fewer and fewer stallions living to continue our species, mating for the purpose of foal-making. What foals are born are more often than not fillies, which, while a wonder, will never be able to breed with one another. Even with our magic, our heritage, it is impossible.”

Celeste closed her eyes, ears flat to her skull and tail clamped down over her hindquarters.

“If we do not find a way, I fear that I will be one of the last of my kind.”

The unicorn trembled, muzzle resting on the wooden table as her tail swished unhappily, back and forth in continuous agitation. In a decidedly equine fashion, for all her heritage, muscle twitched beneath skin, shaking off imagined irritation. It was difficult to shake off an agitation of the mind, as much as her body tried to comply. Christian stroked her neck, pushing his fingers beneath her mane to ease over her warmer skin, hair perfectly free of knots. Magic? He didn’t know what to think anymore. What could he think? His head spun.

“I am sure that won’t happen,” he said lamely. “It would be terrible to see the unicorns disappear...so soon after you made your presence known. All the teachings...” He shuddered, imagining. “A loss too soon would be sorely felt.”

He had no substance to back up his words and sighed, letting his hand drop to his side. What good could he do? She was facing the disappearance of her entire race while the greatest problem he faced was his score in his next exam, the progression of his studies. His life paled in comparison.

To his surprise, Celeste shuffled closer to him, stretching her legs out to the side furthest away from him to ease in beside his chair, her head on the same level of his with a bit of a stretch. Though sadness rimmed her gaze, there was a softness to the orbs that he had not seen before. Instinctively, for it felt like the only right thing to do, he stroked the length of her face, from the base of her horn to the top side of her nose, between the nostrils. She snorted and pushed into his touch.

“At least I was able to meet you, Christian.” She breathed over his cheek, peering down the length of her muzzle at him but having to turn her head slightly to the side to see him clearly. “You’re special. You make me want to fight even harder for the lives of my herd.”

Blushing, he dropped a kiss on her nose, hand gliding down the silken underside of her white-grey neck. Celeste pressed her head down, nudging her forehead against Christian’s as they forgotten their reading and simply breathed in one another’s scents. His partner’s headpiece caught on his hair but Christian could not find it in himself to untangle it. The moment was too idealistic, his dreaming solidified, to spoil. The aroma of aged books enveloped them and Christian slowly inhaled Celeste’s sweet scent: hay, wildflowers and a dab of the equine that made him want to curl into her and stay in the crook of her legs forevermore.

Drawing back enough to look her in the eye, Christian kissed the side of her face, before the curve of her dished cheek, too shy to see if she would accept a more human kiss on the lips.

“Let’s speak of something a bit happier,” he suggested. “I want to see you smile again.”

Christian brushed her forelock to the side and winked, looking into her eye as she whinnied, tail flicking. It was tricky to tell what the tail motions meant but he hoped that her flick was from agreement and not prolonged stress or restlessness.

“Maybe you’d like to hear about my herd?”

“Of course!”

The unicorn turned the page in her book, bringing up an aptly placed unicorn with her head bowed towards a nude male companion. Christian kindly averted his eyes.

“We have fewer unicorns in the herd than we used to, having left for greener pastures. Our homes are on one level as a general rule and mine is the largest in the village at the present time.”

Celeste’s chest puffed out proudly, giving a little toss of her head.

“We do have a library of sorts in my home too, though we do not record histories and stories as you do. They are books on magic and teaching that we record.” She nickered, setting her horn aglow to demonstrate her ability. “For passing this on to the next generation and ensuring that any magic users who come across them in future years are able to take knowledge from them as we do.”

“It sounds like you are renowned in your herd, if you have a library in your own home!” Christian could not deny that he was impressed. “How did that come to be? Why do these books reside with you?”

The unicorn shrugged, head rolling rather than her shoulders, which were tucked too close to her body to allow the motion.

“Likely my position in the herd. My home is the safest place to store them at present, it’s nothing more than that, truly.”

“In fact,” she added, as if struck by a sudden afterthought. “My position in the herd hierarchy is more elevated than I have given consideration in the past. Only my sire and dam are higher than me.”

“Are you the princess of the herd then?” Christian asked with a sidelong wink, fingers tracing over the pages of his book, mind already moving on to the next question he wanted to ask of the stunning unicorn.

“Precisely.”

Christian’s eyes widened and, while he was still digesting the information so casually imparted, Celeste nuzzled her head beneath his chin, careful to keep her horn from smacking him in the face. On autopilot, Christian stroked her cheek, barely touching her skin with the impression of his fingertips in a feather-light caress. Celeste nickered and scooted in closer, beans in the sofa perch crunching beneath the shift of her body.

“Christian, I have many questions to ask of you,” she murmured. “Would you be so kind as to indulge me, now that you know some of my home? I’ve watching you for so long, there is so much I want to know.”

Could he ever refuse her? Settling himself comfortably, Christian smiled to himself, placing each fingertip against its fellow from the opposite hand as Celeste verbally attacked him, a light glow of magic surrounding her body as excitement got the better of her. Words ran into their companions as he did his best to answer each and every one of her curiosities, from his home life to the world he had grown up in. It was going to be a long evening; it was too easy to talk to the unicorn.

And talk they did.

*

Their second date took them out of the city, near the outskirts of where Celeste said her home resided without treading into unicorn territory. Christian exhaled slowly as they reached their destination after a three hour trek, sun high in the sky after an early start. As slow as he walked, Celeste did not leave him for a single second of their journey, close enough to touch and share breath. He had no doubt that Celeste could cover the distance in no time at all. He wondered if another human would have asked to ride her, yet could not imagine him sitting astride the graceful dip of her back, rising to perfectly rounded haunches. She could carry his weight, of course, but it would have felt inherently wrong to do so. As he watched her dip her head to drink, lips breaking the skin of the lake to soothe a thirsty throat, he knew in his heart that it would be the greatest injustice to ever consider treating her as a mere equine.

No. Celeste was far more special than that. His unicorn was unique. He only hoped that Celeste would keep him by her side for...well. Christian blushed and thrust the thought away for another time.

Their trek had brought them to a lake, capped by distant mountains that towered above the line of trees on the opposite shore. Crystal clear water lapped gently at the sand, dotted with smooth pebbles, and Celeste left hoof prints wherever she trod, trotting up and down the

shoreline with a whicker. Kicking up her heels, she bucked for sheer joy, head down between her knees as she dropped to the sand and rolled. It was so purely equine that Christian could not stop himself from laughing, bending over double and succumbing to sheer mirth until his sides ached and Celeste nickered helplessly, legs wagging in the air as if helpless.

She needed her knight to save her! Hurling himself down beside her in a sudden fit of haste to lie beside the unicorn as she rolled herself carefully on to her side, legs angled to the side as her forelegs splayed out before her, poised to drag her body to her hooves once more. He scooted in close to the curve of her side and chuckled as she swung her head around, mane falling over his face to tickle his nose.

“Boo.”

Celeste’s ears twitched.

“What does that mean?”

“It means ‘surprise’!”

Christian laughed as the unicorn shook her head, both amused and despairing at her human’s antics. For all her horseplay, she retained a sense of fineness that Christian could not hope to elevate himself too.

It was a good thing that a regal nature was not a requirement for love, or the droplets of water trickling down the river to something deeper, more wonderful than he could have ever expected.

Blowing Celeste a kiss, Christian scrambled up to perch on a log and slung his backpack down on the sand by his feet. Unzipping it, he rummaged through the interior for his supplies – a well packed lunch that he would not have gone without on any hike. Curious as to why he was yet again hauling around saddle bags, Celeste nickered and thrust her head over his shoulder, eyes bright.

“Are you turning into a pack horse now?” She teased, tail flicking.

Laughing, Christian shook his head and stole a quick kiss, lips brushing hers for the fleetest of heartbeats. Even though their kisses were becoming more familiar, lips learning the nuances of the other, just a single kiss still made his heart skip a beat. He hoped he’d never lose that feeling.

“Not at all. Or at least I hope not,” he said, pulling a sandwich out, wrapped in silver foil. “Would you like anything?”

“Is there anything I can eat in there?”

Christian tapped his nose and dug down to the bottom of the bag, fumbling through snacks and sandwiches until he found the treats he sought carefully encased in clear, malleable plastic wrap.

“Not sure if you’ll have had this before, but it may be something a little different for you.”

Unwrapping the treat, he cupped it in both hands carefully and held it out to the unicorn as if an offering. She sniffed it distrustfully, ears flicking forwards and back as she tried to make sense of the sweet smelling, orange fruit.

“What is it?”

“Mango and pomegranate seeds. It won’t turn your stomach, will it?”

“We’re more resilient than your average horse, Christian,” Celeste said, taking a delicate bite of the fruit and chewing experimentally. “I doubt it will cause me to be unwell, as long as it is not of flesh.” She shuddered. “Meat or even fish will never sit well in our stomachs, although I understand the order of the natural world. It is not for us herbivores.”

Christian made a mental note, thankful that he had solely packed vegetarian meals and snacks that day. He had done well to think ahead. But did her vegetarianism mean that he should abstain from eating meat? Taking a bite of his cheese sandwich – would that be okay too? – he munched thoughtfully, palm dipping as Celeste thrust her nose into it to lick up the last mushy bites of deliciousness. She crunched the seeds between her blunter, flatter teeth and licked her lips.

“Do you have any more?”

Her muzzle was smeared with orange, a crimson seed clinging to her lip as she licked and licked, trying to clear where the mess had spread. Christian chuckled and dabbed at her nose delicately with a tissue while the unicorn grumbled at being cleaned like a ‘foal with her dam’, one front hoof jiggling up and down in midair.

A howl tore apart the sky, slicing through the clouds like an eagle’s talons. Christian froze with a sandwich halfway to his mouth, heart pounding and mouth dry, stillness battling with the urge to leap up and run. But Celeste was right there, ears pricked and eyes bright. She didn’t seem scared. Rubbing his knuckles across his face, he swallowed and listened hard, watching the unicorn out of the corner of his eye. Why did her expressions have to be so difficult to read? With not even a flick to her tail, he could not tell if she was agitated or completely unconcerned by the unearthly shriek.

The silence was unbearable. In the trees, not a single bird chirped. He stared skyward, narrowing his eyes. Was that a shadow he saw? His mind played tricks on him and Christian pressed his palms together, both hands slick with sweat.

“Celeste...” Christian straightened his back slowly from a hunch he had not even known he had sunk into, eyeing his surroundings as his eyes darted from sky to earth as if belonging to a caged animal. “What...was that?”

The unicorn stood stock still, head high and ears pricked as she whuffed and scented the air.

“We are not alone here, Christian.”

The man gulped, sensing the gravity of the situation through her tone, grave and low as she lowered her head to the sand, nostrils flaring.

“Not alone? What do you mean? What the hell made that noise?”

She whirled about, mane and tail flying as she rounded on him, hooves slamming into the sand. The impact sent stinging grains into Christian’s face and he spluttered, flying backwards off the log to land hard on the sand, the wind knocked from his body. He rolled over on to all fours, coughing and retching as he struggled to heave breathe into lungs that no longer wanted to work.

A shadow flashed high above and he dropped to the sand, grains pressing into his cheek. Too big. Much too big to be a bird, even a bird of prey. Yet those had definitely been feathers he’d seen, a wickedly hooked beak designed for rending meat from bone.

Christian gaped as a creature that could not have been a bird and yet flew like one soared overhead, sunlight glinting off deep sapphire feathers. From an avian head, formed like that of an eagle, its plumage extended down to its forelegs, which boasted dagger-like talons, and past its shoulders, from where a pair of similarly coloured wings sprouted to carry its weight through the skies. The resemblance with an avian ended there as feathers melded seamlessly into ashen fur and the hind legs of a feline, claws safely tucked away mid-light. A leonine tail tipped with a tuft of dark blue fur completed the monster’s ensemble and it strung out behind the creature as it circled, watching them below with a lazy, orange eye.

Snapping back to reality, Christian lunged for Celeste, heart hammering so quickly that beats seemed to blur into one thrum of pain and urgency. Sand flew from his heels and he gasped without breath.

“Celeste – get down!”

Christian scrambled up, grabbing her tail in his haste as if he could haul her away from danger through brute force, panic fumbling his actions. The unicorn pawed the sand and nickered, pushing him back firmly but gently so that he was out of the way. Christian’s hands tightened into fists and he pushed with greater vigour, trainers skidding through the sand as he fought for purchase. His actions had as much effect as his hands would have had upon pushing a brick wall, shoving fruitlessly to no means or end.

“Celeste!” He growled, voice taking on a gravelly edge as if that would make her move. “You have to get back! That thing –”

“Do not fear for me, Christian.” Her eyes were warm, if serious with a rim of white. “Please – back. Please go behind me.”

“I’ll never allow harm to come to you, Christian,” she said, setting her horn aglow. “From these unsavoury characters, you have nothing to fear while I am around.”

Her gaze hardened and her horn shot off sparks.

“I’ll make sure of it.”

Putting her body between Christian and the beast, Celeste shot a beam of white light from her horn in challenge as the bird descended, a lazy spiral that brought it closer and closer to earth

at its own pace. It landed on its hind legs, running a few paces until it controlled its speed and smoothed down ruffled feathers to the back of its neck. The creature lifted a forepaw and tapped its beak with two talons, a low croon rolling from its tongue like syrup drooling into water. The sound hung in the air between them and Celeste dipped her head threateningly, putting her horn on show. Laughing, the creature peered around her, meeting the trembling human's eyes. He shuddered.

There was intelligence behind those eyes.

"What's wrong with that one?" It said, head cocked to the side. "Hasn't it ever seen a gryphon before?"

Shaking her mane off her neck, Celeste reared, striking out with her front hooves, hardened bone flashing in the sun.

"Your kind is not welcome here!" She proclaimed, dropping back to all fours. "What business have you so close to the herd?"

The gryphon clacked the edges of his beak together and, though a good head and shoulders shorter than Celeste, strode forward with a confident, easy lope to his stride.

"My dear," he said, for the gryphon was certainly male, "why would you ever think I require business of some sort to take a leisurely flight? Is this not a time to relax as well as conduct business?"

"I would not know the work of your kind," she answered bluntly. "Leave. You are not welcome here."

"Oh, but my friends were oh so looking forward to meeting you, princess," he chuckled, shaking his head; a loose feather drifted to the sand. "Would you leave us so deprived of your company?" He parted his beak, eyes wickedly bright. "I'm confident none of my brethren have seen a human so close either."

The unicorn stamped but the gryphon paid her no mind, sending an eerily bird-like cry up to the sky where no doubt the black dots so high above that Christian had mistaken for birds of prey swiftly took shape. Plummets to the earth, a dark green gryphon and a smaller, more agile russet brown gryphon with feathers the colour of a burned sunset folded their wings in close to their bodies in a sheer, reckless dive. Wind whipping past their bodies, they shrieked in pure joy at their speed, spiralling as they rocketed closer and closer to the ground, birds scattering from the trees on their approach. At the last possible second, they pulled up, wings flared and trembling, to clatter over the pebbles closer to the shoreline, squabbling between each other as their landing brought them within snapping distance.

One eye on Celeste, the sapphire gryphon welcomed them with a soft purr, unnervingly like that of a domestic cat. Christian was abruptly back home in his childhood home, ramshackle, with the adopted ginger tomcat curled up in a ferocious ball on his lap. Yet his stubborn pet had likely never been the hunter these creatures of sky and earth resonated with every step.

"Sharptalon, so good of you to join us..."

The sapphire gryphon purred, butting his head against that of his fellow in a comradely fashion, tail whipping back and forth. The third gryphon – a female, from the lither sway of her body – shrieked and flapped her wings, rearing back on her hind legs as if to mimic Celeste’s threat. Refusing to rise to the bait, she stood stoic as the gryphons bantered amongst themselves, waiting for them to conclude their ostentatious display. She had no need of such frivolities when her status more than spoke for itself. Subtly, she shifted her bulk closer to Christian, shielding him completely from view.

“I am Sharptalon,” the green gryphon introduced himself unnecessarily, blue eyes kinder than that of the first gryphon who was showing such an interest in Christian. “This is my sister, Sunwing. Are you the unicorn princess of the forest?”

Celeste did not dignify them with an answer, instead hardening her gaze and locking it on the blue gryphon, whose eyes never left Christian, legs barely visible below the curve of her stomach. Her horn crackled with sparks and a cloud, wispy yet viable, passed in front of the sun, casting their affront into grey gloom. Celeste angled her head towards the gryphon, who would have smirked if his beak would have allowed the motion.

“And yourself?”

She kept her tone carefully bored, though Christian was pressed close enough to her side to feel her pulse racing. The blue gryphon squawked and pranced, dancing on his paws and talons as if he had become an equine himself, so light of foot was he. He pushed his chest out.

“I would have thought you would have heard of a great hunter such as myself.” He fluffed up his feathers importantly, strutting back and forth. “I am Nighthunter, the strongest hunter in the forest. No,” he corrected himself, “the fiercest hunter in all the lands.”

Christian rolled his eyes, tucked safely at the point where Celeste’s barrel met her hindquarters, tail flicking and catching his side every few seconds, the only outward sign of her agitation. With three gryphons staring him down, it seemed like a ridiculous idea to have tried to protect Celeste. He was abruptly aware of how small he was in her world, one where creatures he had once deemed mythical thrived. He shivered. Did they hunt humans? Would mankind have ever allowed that?

Would mankind have ever even found out about it?

“A brag, but he is the greatest hunter we know,” Sharptalon confirmed, though Christian swore the gryphon rolled his eyes. “I would not have it denied.”

Nighthunter preened, sinking back on to his haunches as if he had not a care in the world.

“And I have set my sights on fresh prey.”

Demonstrating surprising limberness, he licked the edge of his beak with a very pink tongue, moistening it much a like a human being would if faced with the annoyance of a dry mouth.

“Hand the human over, Celeste,” Nighthunter growled, body stiff and tense. “This is the prey I wish to hunt. You evidently have no need of a human. Put him into our talons.”

Stiffening, Celeste held her head high, a tight arch to her neck. Christian shrank in closer to her, hoping that she could not feel him shake. But there was a gryphon over there *talking about hunting him*. Swallowing, he twisted his fingers into her mane for courage, reality increasingly more fragile. Celeste was his anchor. She would protect him. He hardened his gaze. And he would protect her.

“I hardly believe that is going to happen,” she said coolly, turning her body side-on to the gryphons and raising a hind hoof. “It is *outlawed* to hunt humans. You know this as well as I. We have no business with the humans and they leave our lands alone.”

Well, that answered that question of his and raised twenty more. He wanted to be brave – so badly! – but how was he supposed to stand his ground when such a beast looked him over as if he was a slab of steak? He supposed that, to the gryphon, that’s all he was.

Summoning the dregs of courage he did not know he possessed, Christian clenched a fist and stepped around Celeste, despite her shuffling protests, the unicorn struggle to keep an eye on him and the gryphons simultaneously. Standing tall, he set his gaze on the gryphons, larger than he and exuding a confidence he could never hope to match. Something in them told him that they embodied

But predators had their weaknesses.

“I’m not going anywhere with you,” Christian said, voice shaking, one hand just below Celeste’s withers. “Even if I was alone, do you think I would come easily?” Emboldened once he’d begun, Christian ploughed on. “Must you hunt in a pack to take down the weakest of prey, without even a single weapon to raise against you?”

Sharptalon bristled but Nighthunter stilled him by raising a claw like a human would lift a hand to stay a sharp comment.

“Some would consider it an honour to be taken by a gryphon, boy,” he commented.

“Not me.” He laughed dryly, dark humour returning some of the colour to his cheeks. “Some hunter you are if your style of hunting is talking your prey to death.”

Nighthunter tensed, muscle taut beneath fur and feathers. Christian caught his breath and Celeste pawed the ground, kicking up clods of sand from the frog of her hoof. Muddied grains, no two the same shade, clung to the hoof and Christian watched the grains spray back as if in slow motion, power constrained within a single limb. Adrenaline pumped through his veins and, for a moment, he believed the gryphons would back down, proclaim it was all a misunderstanding.

The problem was that gryphons were not known for their diplomacy.

Nighthunter snarled, the sound ripped from his throat with barbs to rival the tongue of many a rival. Celeste neighed a warning, lifting her front hooves a few inches from the sand: *stay back!* He laughed at her defence, slinking down low to the ground as his fellows shuffled their wings and clacked their beaks, paws and claws shifting from one spot to another.

“No matter then,” Nighthunter growled, crouching low to the ground as his tail lashed restlessly. “It is more entertaining to take prey by force. In what else does the thrill of the hunt lie?”

Christian took a step back, unwittingly leaving the safety of Celeste’s side as the gryphon approached, his stance deadly. Far from the cocky feline he had appeared on first landing and engaging with Celeste, there was a new, hungry glimmer in his eye that struck a chill into Christian’s heart.

Celeste! She was away from him – too far away! He felt all too acutely the empty space between them and flung his arm out to her as the gryphon sank back on his hind legs, power building like the coil of a spring, ready to pounce.

“Stay away!”

Celeste reared, a quick twist of her body throwing Christian off his feet and out of reach of her flashing hooves, quick to strike justice. Sapphire flashed through the air, too quick for the eye to see, and, winded on the ground, Christian rolled out of the way as his protector leapt over him. An unearthly shriek to match the gryphon’s emanated, somehow, from Celeste as the white unicorn spun with the greatest finesse to slam her back hooves into the gryphon’s gut as he lunged for them, eyes blazing.

It was a crude blow, yet an effective one. Nighthunter recoiled, hacking as the breath was knocked from him, but swiftly recovered, spreading his paws for balance, warier than he had been on his first attack. The unicorn was not a half-feral horse to be taken down without a fight. He should have known that. The gryphon snarled and attacked all the more fiercely, feathers flying as he lunged, beak a wide, black gape. One snap of that beak and Celeste’s neck would be snapped like a twig if the gryphon got hold of her. Christian’s heart drummed, aching to help yet knowing he’d be helpless. As Celeste spun, batting the gryphon away with her front hooves, he dragged his gaze from left to right, looking for anything – anything at all! – that may be used to help her. Yet all he could do was stay out of the way, more vulnerable as a human than she as a unicorn.

Celeste’s horn shone with a golden beam of light, shooting upwards with visible force that lifted her back up and away from her neck. Christian curled his fingers into the damp sand, even in the pit of battle struck by her beauty. Sharptalon scurried to Nighthunter’s side and hissed, both stalking forward to flank the unicorn on two sides. Gathering herself, Celeste took an uncertain step backwards, tossing her head as her hind hooves sank into a patch of damper sand, clogged by a rivulet of water. She stumbled and Christian lurched to his feet, slinging a pebble so that it skittered across the talons of both advancing gryphons.

Shot!

“Oi!” He bellowed, dragging air into his lungs to force his voice to carry. “Some predators you are! Ganging up in a pack!” He laughed, putting as much derision into the sound as possible as Celeste found firm footing once more. “You can’t even hunt alone. Are you sure you’re gryphons at all?”

The gryphons glanced back and that was enough time for Celeste to cloak herself in magic, form shimmering as she threw up a silvery barrier that shocked the gryphons like a jolt of

electricity. Stunned, they rocked their heads back and forth, shook themselves, and turned to easier, unshielded prey. Christian gulped. Move! He shook himself and scrambled upright, darting behind a weather beaten log with gnarled, whitened roots reaching towards the sky, grabbing another fistful of pebbles, for what little good they would do him. The best thing he could do was not hinder her so that she could see their unwelcome guests off in style as only she knew how.

Celeste charged, head down and horn raised as the gryphons screeched and leapt for Christian, flapping to take flight a metre or so above the ground – not hard enough to gain any true altitude. He ducked and a brilliant ray of light shot over head as Celeste counter attacked, spearing them with a point of magic that seared off feathers with a black singe of burning. Their fellow screeched, flapping her wings erratically and Nighthunter hissed as he whipped around, hardly dissuaded by the attack. He'd had worse and Celeste knew it, drawing. It was not her forte – what unicorn would enjoy battle? Her eyes narrowed at the corners and she snorted, nostrils showing a red slash of heat within.

Holding no magic of his own, Nighthunter was not about to give up and fainted to the left, darting for the unicorn's flank as she sidestepped, nearly on top of Sharptalon. Further back, pacing anxiously back and forth with her tail whipping, Sunwing shrieked and flapped like a fledgling toppled out of the nest. As Sharptalon struck, Christian cried out, hanging around his shelter of roots but had nothing to be concerned over.

He should have more faith in her strength, he berated himself, watching in open awe as she handled herself more than admirably. Ducking away from the sharp talons, Celeste blocked the gryphon's swipe with solidified magic, using it much like a shield to beat him back. Voice curling into an equine scream that he could hardly believe came from her lips, Celeste bucked, twisted and slammed her magic into the gryphons, catching Nighthunter with the full brunt of it. Only dealt a glancing blow, Sharptalon squawked indignantly, only taking pause and stock of the situation when he caught sight of Nighthunter sprawled out on the ground, lifting his head weakly. Hatred burned in the gryphon's eyes.

But Celeste had already won.

"Begone with you!" She cried, magic warping the air around her body so that her shape flitted in and out of visibility. "I'll have no more of your silken tongue, though I can say nothing for your talons! They are blunted by your ways and your feathers dull from trespass. You have no meaning to be here!"

"Nighthunter..." The female gryphon, Sunwing, crawled on the ground to his side, belly rubbing through damp sand. "Nighthunter, are you well? Can you take flight?"

"Well enough to fight!" Nighthunter growled, struggling to his feet, although one wing drooped dangerously low, betraying some injury. "Stand against me, unicorn, and we shall see who truly deserves to rule our forest! You have reigned for far too long!"

"Nighthunter! Have some sense!" Sunwing snapped, speaking up at long last, though she cast Celeste a hateful look. "Up on your paws! We must fly! The alpha must hear of this!"

The mention of the alpha – was that like in a wolf's pack? – seemed to jolt him into action. Nighthunter heaved himself up, one wing drooping yet not broken. He stretched it out,

wincing. It would pain him to fly but would not hold him back. Snarling, he turned his back on the unicorn, spraying a derisive jet of urine from his feline hindquarters, a feeble attempt to mark territory that he believed should always have been his, always that of gryphon-kind.

Celeste wrinkled her nose and stared Nighthunter down until he turned tail, shoulders slumping.

“You may return, but you shall never claim what you seek.”

Celeste shot off a spray of sparks from her horn, merely for show, but they got the gryphons moving, trotting along the sand as their wings pumped, skipping into the air.

“We shall meet again, *princess*,” Nighthunter cawed, voice almost drowned out by the laboured flapping of his wings. “And, next time, you shall have a very different kind of gryphon to deal with. One that you will always regret crossing.”

Christian edged away from the shelter of the tree, lips twisting as the roots cast long, gnarled shadows across the sand like the fingers of a great beast. The problem, however, was that beasts were becoming enemies as much as friends, showing themselves beyond the outskirts of lands mankind had claimed. The myths were still very much alive and kicking. And they were coming.

He rested a hand on Celeste’s neck and stroked gently as she nickered, hiding her distress behind a nudge of her muzzle into his chest – too brief for the gryphons to notice.

Nighthunter would not leave without one last jab, however, and called back as they flew nearly out of earshot.

“Unicorns will *not* survive!”

Celeste shuddered and Christian murmured sweet nothings into her ear, holding her as tight to him as was physically possible until her trembles subsided, knees once again steady. The day had drawn on and sunset crept across the land, touching the lake with shades of red and orange. Once again, the crackle of magic fading from her horn, Christian was stunned by her form and poise, not a hair out of place even after a fight in which she had charged across half the sands and back – all to defend him. How could he ever match up to such a breathtaking? Without her, he would surely be carried off by a gryphon to only heaven knew where.

He shook his head and stepped closer, breathing in her sweet scent in slow, deep breaths as if she was the elixir through which his life may be lived.

“You saved me, Celeste,” he said simply, arms around her neck and face buried in her mane. “You protected me...” Words seemed too much, too cliché. “How can I ever repay you, my sweet? What can I ever do for you that can meet every drop of what you do for me?”

“Oh Christian,” she murmured, licking the back of his neck where his hairline began. “You should already know the answer to that one, truly and absolutely.”

She lifted her head to look into his eyes, a light breeze lifting her mane from her neck as her white coat glowed pink in the sunset.

“I’ll always be your white knight.”

*

“Are you sure this is okay?” Christian asked, peering around the birch tree with silver, peeling bark.

Keeping his distance, he followed Celeste with slow, careful footsteps as if afraid of where he was putting his feet. Everywhere he tread seemed to be covered in pristine moss and wildflowers, colours so vibrant that he felt an imposter simply walking through the grove at the unicorn’s heels, following as obediently as a trained puppy. Brushing a hand through his roughed up hair, Christian made no attempt to avert his eyes from Celeste’s behind, rippling with muscle as she strode forward confidently. He only just got his gaze innocently away in time when the unicorn turned, encouraging him with a little bob of her head.

“Nearly there.”

She walked on, giving him no choice but to follow. It was not as if he didn’t want to see Celeste’s home – he was more curious than he cared to admit – but he half dreaded what the other unicorns would make of him. He would be walking in with their *princess*. He still wasn’t sure he’d wrapped his head around that. Undoubtedly the herd would be as polite and friendly as Celeste, though he couldn’t deny that it would be intimidating. At least she’d promised him that her parents were away for the time being, on royal business no doubt. He licked his lips nervously, wondering if they were meeting with the gryphons and their alpha, the memory of a few weekends ago

Time passed so quickly with Celeste but he had other matters to concern himself with as they approached two unicorns in dun and black, coats gleaming even in the low light of oncoming evening. Christian winced, feet sore; it had been an excessively long walk but it was understandable why the unicorns lived so far from civilisation. Although the pair of unicorns, who could have been guards, eyed Celeste but dipped their heads respectfully to allow them to pass, not a word passing their lips.

Stepping between them, Christian tried not to stare. He had ‘his’ own unicorn to stare at, though thought he was more hers than she was his. She led him into a village composed of open shelters for socialising, formed from all natural materials with leaves for the roof – likely kept in place through magical means. At first he found it odd that they were all single storey abodes until he remembered that, of course, stairs would be more difficult for an equine and a hindrance rather than a help. As familiar as Celeste now was to him, it was easy to forget that she walked on four legs.

As they moved further into the village, with plenty of space between large, roomy homes, unicorn after unicorn poked out curious muzzles, eyes bright and ears twitching. A human! Whatever next? He huddled into Celeste’s side, trying to seem as small as possible and simultaneously take in every unicorn surrounding him, the herd closing in. Eventually, it was impossible for Celeste to make further progress and she came to a halt, tail swishing rhythmically over her hindquarters. It was all Christian could do to not turn his head to watch its progress over that beautiful rump

The nearest unicorn, a darker silver-grey with a slice of pink on his nose, stretched out his head as if to touch Christian's arm. Green eyes warm, he whinnied a welcome, upper lip briefly curling back from his teeth. Snorting, Celeste rested the tip of one hind hoof on the luscious grass, every inch the image of equine impatience. Christian scratched her shoulder gently, pretending his palms weren't sweating like a waterfall.

Celeste nosed the other unicorn in greeting, appearing as familiar with him as she would be a brother. He, for his barrel left little to the imagination, squealed and pranced like a colt, head thrown back as the herd shifted in response, one organism breathing as one.

"Quiet!" Celeste nickered, eyes dancing. "You will frighten this one if you crowd him!"

"What have you returned with this time, Celeste?" The stallion nickered, head bobbing as he "A pleasure to meet you, sir. What would your name be?"

"I'm Christian." Feeling oddly formally, he planted his feet together and bowed shallowly – it was not as if he could shake the stallion's hoof. "A pleasure to meet you too..."

He let his last word hang in the air and the unicorn finished for him, head lifting higher.

"Diernon." He introduced himself. "I'm Celeste's cousin."

"Although your act denotes you as a ruffian of a donkey rather than one in the royal line." Celeste quipped, a smile on her muzzle. "Alas, we must endure your presence for you have some redeeming features."

He squealed, mock affronted by her comment. Even as he reared, the smile never left his eyes and Christian laughed along with the rippling nickers of the herd. Their laughter was as infectious as Celeste's.

Emboldened by Diernon, other members of the herd stepped forward to greet him, welcome on their lips, but Celeste stamped a hoof, shuffling them back. She shook her head, mane spilling to the other side of her neck, head arching around Christian as if to block him from view. There was nothing, however, that he required protection from and he craned his head around her, smiling at a younger, slimmer chestnut mare who could have only been born a year or two prior. It was good to see young life in an otherwise mature herd.

"Enough of this," Celeste said, hustling Christian along as the herd made a path for her, curiosity sated for the moment. "You shall meet Christian and confer as much as your hearts desire. But that must wait for another time."

She made no further explanation as she nudged him in the small of his back, encouraging him on as his step faltered, eyes roaming. Perhaps a princess did not need to explain every word. Regardless, he had plenty to look at as they made their way through the village at a brisk pace, more open shelters for socialising and communal dining for feasts beckoning him in with lowered tables and slots within for fine food to heaped safely, contained by what reminded him of a 'hay bar' for horses.

A larger dwelling with precious gems set into the white stone walls – magically enhanced, he could only suspect – lay ahead, commanding attention as the largest abode in the village. Set

apart from every other shelter in the village, every colour glimmered in the walls, dragging Christian's attention from one glimmer to the next in excessively swift succession. Christian looked up at the huge, wooden double doors permitting entrance, reaching out to Celeste for reassurance. The warmth of her coat never failed to slow the frantic pace of his heart and bring it to a new kind of beat entirely.

Celeste brushed her nose against his cheek as they approached, tail lifted high, keen for something Christian did not know in that instant.

"This is my home."

Opening the doors with magic, she brought him through the private gardens of her family, full of flora that Christian had thought had died out many years ago in all the colours of the rainbow. There was no pause to admire as she smiled and led him through into the hallways, wooden floors and smooth walls ingrained with the memory of wood making him feel as if he was inside a tree itself. Indeed, living branches and roots curled from walls and floor, an essential part of the abode as nature thrived on unicorn life and unicorn life thrived on nature.

It was a beautiful companionship.

Taking him through the rooms in her home, she showed him a sliver of her world, for it would have taken many days for him to absorb everything. Eventually, he found himself herded up a slope with a gentle gradient to a private room with a bed set into the floor. Shivering, for it was surely Celeste's bedroom she had finally brought him to at the conclusion of their trek, he tried not to look at the bed for too long, instead sweeping his gaze around the tapestries layering the walls to depict scenes of unicorns. Her history? He was sure he would have the answer if he did but ask. Christian paused at the window, high enough to look out over the village in its entirety between the trees and, a little further afield, the sparkle of a lake stroked by sunset. He sighed. Was it so late already?

"Your home is lovely, Celeste," he said politely, hands clasped behind his back as if to push his chest out. "But surely we must be leaving once more? It is nearing nightfall and it will be quite a trek

He frowned, scratching his forearm. His fingernails rasped through a light coating of dark hair to match the mop atop his scalp.

"If you're tired, you don't have to walk me back either." He assured. "I'm sure I can find my way back through the forest." Christian chuckled. "I have my torch still."

Celeste paused before her bed, piled with soft blankets and layered in a way that reminded Christian of a stable made warm for the night. While far from a straw or shavings deep pile bed, he supposed her joints required the same. Did she sleep standing up like an equine or did her magic prevent her organs from becoming crushed beneath the weight of her body if she chose to sleep lying down for an extended span of time? He brimmed with curiosity, though patted his pockets down to check he had everything he started off with, disappointed to be leaving so soon. He'd have to be off soon.

“Christian...” The unicorn shook her head, horn dipping from side to side as her violet eyes twinkled, taking on new life. “Do you think I would have brought you to my bedchambers if I intended to send you traipsing back through the forest tonight?”

Christian blinked and the unicorn laughed, soft peals musical and contained by the tapestries adorning the walls – there was no echo. Dumbfounded, he glanced back at the entranceway, devoid of privacy allowing door, and gulped. Hard.

“Oh.”

What could he say? His thoughts raced, following the implications of the bedchamber. Did she mean what he thought she meant? He scratched his nose, buying himself time as the unicorn watched him curiously, waiting on a response that was taking too long to pass his lips. Christian rocked back on his heels. No, no: he couldn’t jump to conclusions.

“So, I’ll be sleeping here tonight?”

He phrased it as a question, voice rising a pitch higher at the end of his utterance, and Celeste giggled, muzzle dipping to nudge lightly into his stomach.

“I know we shall be doing a great deal more than simply sleeping, Christian.”

He took a step back towards the bed as Celeste advanced, a unicorn that knew exactly what she wanted and how she was going to get it. Slowly, she lifted her head to the same level of his and pressed their lips together, tongue flicking out over Christian’s lips in mimicry of a human kiss. It was as clumsy as their first kiss yet all the sweeter for what was to come, lips and tongues making do with bodies that were never inherently designed to mould together perfectly. Hesitantly, Christian returned her kiss, passion deepening as he reached up to twine his fingers into her mane. He had to stand on his tip-toes to reach her poll when her head was at such an angle, lips turned up to meet her velvety embrace.

Trailing his fingers down her neck, Christian shivered, admiring her form openly as Celeste invited his gaze in. Turning side-on to him, she arched her neck proudly and lifted a hind hoof as if to tense the muscle of her hindquarters, showing off her body with the air of a mare who knew every bit how alluring she was. She was also a mare that had little patience when it came to romance – even for her first time.

“Take off your clothes,” she nickered. “You see me as I truly am every time we meet. I wish to see you as you are, Christian, too.”

She was quick! Christian’s eyes roamed her body from the curve of her neck to smooth hindquarters, tail lifted high. There was no question what she wanted; the unicorn was as direct as ever and it both excited and terrified him. He fiddled with the neck of his jacket, suddenly feeling very bare despite his clothing. What would she think of him? There was no way to tell except to take the plunge.

Celeste nuzzled his neck, soft lips caressing and coaxing a moan from his lips as his head rolled back. Christian pulled back with difficulty, pressing his forehead to hers, gathering courage.

“I think I’ll look very different to you than one of your stallions,” he said, twisting his fingers together, catching flakes of rough skin. “I hope...” He hesitated, eyes lowering, “you won’t be disappointed.”

Dropping his rucksack, ever present on his hikes with the mare, on the floor, he slowly complied, fingers trembling so badly that it was difficult to unzip his sweatshirt and slip it back off his shoulders. It was something to do, however, and kept him occupied as he tried not to compare himself to a stallion, hopelessly outclassed in the only way that seemed to matter to males.

“There would never be anything to compare,” she murmured sweetly.

Spurred on by her confidence in him, Christian slowly stripped away first his t-shirt, dragging it up over his head, and then his hiking trousers, peeling off the light, brown fabric as if removing a second skin. And, in a way, that was exactly what he was doing, cutting away layer after layer until he became nothing more than his true self with nothing to hide behind. The mare watched him intently, her expression unreadable as he struggled with his clothing. Was he doing it right?

Christian fought not to clench his jaw so hard that the mare would notice, making his movements as smooth and seamless as possible, consciously blending one into the other as he stripped. Surely the mare could tell that he was a virgin? Christian cursed himself, fumbling with his boots as his trousers tangled around his ankles. He should have taken the damn things off first! He wrestled them off and kicked his trousers aside, a finger sliding under the waistband of his underwear. Red and blue, a designer brand that had been gifted by a friend. He had never been so glad at reaching laundry day, dipping down to a pair of boxer briefs so rarely worn that they appeared to be brand new out of the packet.

Steadying himself, he slid his boxer briefs down his legs, revealing his hardening shaft, plumping with the hint of arousal. He hesitated, surprised at himself – how could he be turned on when his heart pounded so hard that it was painful? And yet...how could he not be aroused by such a magnificent unicorn?

For the first time, he paused, distracting himself by taking stock of Celeste. Although she had worn nothing for the course of their walk, finding it too warm to adorn herself comfortably, in his distraction she had slipped into something to accentuate her figure. A necklace curled about her neck, mimicking how a lady’s pendant would dip towards human breasts and sparkling with so many rubies that the eye could not comprehend its value. A light harness rested over her withers and down the length of her back, reminiscent of what a carriage horse may have worn in style only. Formed of finely woven dark fabric, it was also covered in so many rubies that the fabric itself was barely visible, reaching down under her barrel and looping beneath her tail as if to hold it up for attention.

Angling herself so that her lifted tail was on display, Celeste flashed him a glimpse of her sex, puffy lips winking invitingly. Unlike an equine, two pairs of udders swelled before the join of her hind legs, teats appearing so tantalising that Christian was hit by the sudden, inexplicable urge to wrap his lips around them and *suck*. Her sex seemed larger than he had expected – not that he had spent much time considering her cunny – with a needy nub of a clit at the base, pulsing with blood.

“Celeste...” He shook his head, caressing her with his gaze. “You truly are the most beautiful mare – no, the most beautiful *lady* I have ever had the good fortune to lay eyes on.”

Giggling like a filly, Celeste swatted him playfully with her tail and traced her nose down his chest, warm breath washing over his nipples and lower abdomen as she explored.

“Christian.” There was a smile in her voice. “I have felt your eyes on me on every single one of our walks. You are an easy one to read, once I knew you.”

She paused, eyes sincere.

“And I hope to know you better now.”

Transfixed, Christian allowed the mare to guide him to the bed and joined her as she gracefully folded herself to the blankets, legs tucked beneath her. She arched her neck and whickered, tossing her head as she thrust her tail wantonly to one side, muscle quivering beneath skin. He took the invitation at his own pace, nerves stilled by the comfort of being so close to the one he loved. Kissing down her neck, he made his way down to her withers and lathered attention upon her back, fingers massaging and stroking in slow deep circles, increasing the pressure as she responded.

Shivering beneath him, the unicorn twisted her head around as he moved further down her body, brushing her muzzle over his shoulders in a fleeting kiss. He dropped kiss after kiss over her hindquarters, spreading his hands wide as if to caress every inch of her at once, although that was impossible. Her body stirred the pit of need deep inside him and Christian groaned, cock rising as blood filled it, pressing against Celeste’s coat with a soft yet insistent nudge.

“I didn’t know unicorns would have two udders,” he said, running his hand over her rump, careful of her jewellery. “Is that something all unicorns have? I mean,” he added hastily, “all mares?”

“The mares in the herd are known to add an additional pair with magic, if they possess the skill. I enjoy the effect myself.”

She nickered, stretching out her neck.

“They are particularly sensitive.”

Oh, really now? Christian grinned, out of the mare’s line of sight. Slipping behind her, he was treated to a perfect unobstructed view of her sex, which flexed in a wink, Celeste’s nostrils flaring as she breathed. He knelt and bravely kissed over the curve of her rump, every kiss landing him closer to her marehood. She nickered, impatient, but he took his time, fingers circling the inside of her upper legs, finding flesh that had never before been caressed, or at least never so intimately.

His teasing could not last long with such a demanding mare, however, and Christian feared, in a flicker of amusement, that she could pin him to the bed if he did not give her the attention she desired. Nuzzling beneath her tail, the soft flap of flesh twitching to his touch, he pressed his lips to her sex and slipped out his tongue to stroke over each puffy lip in turn.

His faint touch grew bolder with every lap and he pushed his face in closer, gently circling her enlarged clit and increasing the pressure as she snorted heavily, body heating up to his touch. Sparks shot from her horn, control slipping, and Christian moaned, arousal dripping on to his tongue, sweeter than honey straight from the source. He boldly licked two fingers to moisten them and eased them into her sex, finding courage he did not know he had in the reserves of his consciousness. Celeste groaned, barrel resonating, and he grinned, dropping his thumb down to her clit for additional stimulation.

Christian wracked his brain, divided between act and memory, for anything that would help him in the moment. He was vastly unprepared and he knew it. Although he understood the mechanics of sex and had read and watched enough online to know enough to experiment with what made a lady 'happy', every step was new to him. He could only try and see how the unicorn would react, hoping for the best. Luckily, he seemed to be on the right track, mimicking how a stallion would thrust into her as he plunged two and then three digits deep.

Celeste grew impatient, hooves pushing out to scrape over her bed and push the blankets into disarray. Teasing, for the penetration could not possibly be as pleasurable as being mounted by a male of her kind, Christian lapped her clit more enthusiastically, his free hand holding her rump firmly as she rocked, tail dangling over his head like a silken waterfall. The more stimulation he provided, the greater her response, seeming to require no gentle approach as she panted and whispered for more. Christian worked his fingers inside her, lips locked around her clitoris in a long, hard suck.

And that did it.

"Mount me!" She neighed, kicking as if she would leap to her hooves and do it herself if he did not comply. "I need you inside me, Christian, please breed me as your mare."

Hands shaking, he scrambled back from her rump as her tail slapped him in the chest, the mare's lips parted in a pant that should not have been natural for one of her kind. Her eyes were glassy with lust and he stroked her rump with as soothing a hand as he could manage, holding his shaft in the other. It throbbed and he gnawed the inside of his cheek, quelling the wave of nausea – solely from nerves – threatening to overcome him.

He leaned forward, spreading his feet apart until he was at the right level and tipping over her hindquarters, nudging the tip of his cock against her engorged lips, swollen with blood. At even that light touch, Celeste trembled, winking furiously. There could be no doubt over what she wanted. Unlike with a human female, there was no awkward jabbing and prodding with his cock: her marehood drew him in like a target, heat searing the tip. Holding his breath, he slowly pushed the head in, groaning deep in his throat as warmth enveloped his shaft.

Celeste's flanks heaved with breath as he sank his full length into her, tail pushed up and trapped between her rump and Christian's abdomen. The unicorn mare rumbled a groan that reverberated through her barrel, head angled to the side so that she could watch Christian pushing into her. He drew back when his crotch pressed flush to her rump, breath catching. He could never have imagined that it would be so difficult to hold himself back, self-control lacking when it came to the crunch. He closed his eyes, though that only made it worse, overcome by the sound of Celeste's heavy breathing and sweet, flowery scent combined with heady arousal. Every inch of him simply wanted to thrust deep and stay there forever.

A greater part of him wanted to thrust like the stallion she deserved.

Resting there, Christian caught himself, the need to spill his seed stirring even after only being inside the mare for less than the span of a human minute.

“I may not last very long,” he whispered, twisting his fingers into the mane at the very base of her neck. “I’m... I’m a virgin. I hope you don’t mind.”

It was difficult to mind anything buried balls deep in the stunning creature. The unicorn shook her head, mane flipping back and forth from each side of her neck.

“I am also one, Christian,” she said softly. “This is my first mating.”

He stilled, eyes wide.

“Really?” He blurted out, hips juddering accidentally and grinding his cock in deeper – they both moaned. “But...but you’re so confident! How can you be a virgin when you’re...so forward?”

It felt lame to say aloud and Christian cursed himself, dropping his hand from the unicorn’s rump to his side, where it hung limply. Celeste laughed, heat colouring the insides of her ears. Even her normally pink nose was a darker shade: a unicorn blush.

“Why should I be so shy when I know I love you deeply?”

The outside world ceased to exist – or at least that was so in Christian’s eyes. No, he couldn’t have heard her correctly. Celeste had not just said... But it was true. And it was the most wonderful, glorious truth! His heart soared, returning to a beat that he had not known it had skipped.

“I love you too, Celeste,” he murmured, wiping away the threat of tears from his eyes. “Ever so much. I’m so glad I found you.”

Blowing her a kiss, for he could not reach her lips, Christian squeezed her hindquarters, fat layered softly upon firm, powerful muscle, and thrust like he had dreamed of. Rolling his hips, he rested his weight on her as he thrust, sweat beading on his forehead to roll languidly down his face. She clenched around him as if threatening to refuse to allow him to pull back, her passage squeezing and rippling with a near vice-like grip. With her squeezing so wantonly around him, it was tricky to move and he threw his bodyweight into his thrusts, grunting and huffing for breath like a stud. Or at least he imagined himself to be one.

The unicorn trembled, skin shivering. Though she could not rock back into him as she wished, she dug her forelegs into her bed and pushed back as much as she was able, encouraging him harder and deeper. Tail pressed against her lover’s stomach, she snorted and moaned, horn glowing with a faint, golden aura. Each plunge into her cunny made her body thrum with pleasure and she nickered as Christian slipped his hand down to her clit, fingers rubbing in tight circles to give her even more pleasure.

The sensation built and built until even the unicorn found it hard to believe she could contain it any longer.

“Mmm...” She moaned, eyes rolling back. “We shall make this last, Christian. Will you withdraw from me? There is something I have in mind to try.”

Reluctantly, he pulled out, shaft slick from their combined sexual fluids. Muscles aching from the position he had been holding, Christian slipped to his knees, a low groan passing his lips as pain tingled through his legs. Who could have known that sex required such energy? Or maybe that was just with Celeste?

The unicorn stood, hoof slipping on the blankets in her haste, and turned to face him, muzzle dropping to the level of his stomach. She nuzzled down his abdomen, huffing warm breath, and tapped him with her horn as her lips brushed his cock. Christian jumped and blushed, lifting his hands to rest them on her head behind her ears, from where they slipped back to scratch her neck lovingly. It would have felt wrong to hold her head or restrain her in any way.

Nuzzling lower, the unicorn flicked her tongue out experimentally to lick the top side of his shaft, wrinkling her nose at the taste. Christian could not tell what he tasted like.

“Uh...Celeste?” He shifted uncertainly as she took a second lick and then another, horn faintly glowing gold. “What are you...mmm...”

He broke in a groan and she did not reply, nudging her horn into his side as she turned her head, lips parted to take him into her mouth. He froze, worried of her blunt teeth, but Celeste carefully pressed her lips around his shaft, soft warmth encasing him as he thrust in over her tongue. Christian did not know what oral with a human woman would have been like and never wished to know otherwise. Rolling his head back, he moaned open-mouthed and Celeste pushed her nose down to the curl of hair at his crotch, nostrils flared to their full extent. Fearing for her breath, he tugged lightly on her mane and she pulled back along his length briefly, only to plunge down again with a trembling snort.

Hips rolling without conscious thought, Christian rubbed behind her ears and tried not to think of how good her tongue felt squeezed to the underside of his cock. It curled around the head as she bobbed her muzzle, withdrawing only far enough to mimic his thrusts into a partner – her! – and stoke the embers of passion into a roaring blaze of a fire. Magic flowed from her horn, flowing into him like water, and he almost backed away from its warmth, a tingle of something otherworldly trickling down to his cock. He settled when he realised it caused him no harm but, somehow, the pleasure rocketed skywards like the flight of a bird, becoming almost too potent to bear. Gasping, he held on to her mane for support, legs spread and still unsteady as Celeste suckled, lips pursed tightly around him. Orgasm threatened with a jerk of his hips and Christian jerked away with a cry, standing shaking with only the tip of his cock still between her lips, fighting off climax with mental tooth and claw. The unicorn rumbled softly, barrel vibrating.

As much as the unicorn loved to repay with teasing, however, she wanted something else more. Need set her winking cunny afire and she pulled off his cock with a slurp of pre cum, throwing her head back. The unicorn stamped and neighed shrilly, thrusting her head over Christian’s shoulder as they clung to each other, hearts racing.

“I cannot wait!” Celeste huffed, tail flagged as high as it had been in the beginning. “Christian! I need you to breed me! Hard as a stallion!”

He needed no further encouragement as the mare spun, diving for her bed and rolling on to her back, legs flung up in the air. He almost giggled but caught himself just in time – it would not do to laugh at her in the bedchambers – easing between her legs and pushing them apart a little further with the flat of his hands. His cock found her marehood without his direction and he stroked her belly as he thrust in, their moans sounding in perfect unison.

Celeste’s magic strengthened within him and Christian inhaled sharply as her passage grew tighter around him – was she climaxing? He thumbed her clit but she made no motion of sensitivity. Thrusting, he gripped her legs and gave a strangled grasp, head swimming. Was his shaft...larger? It swelled before his eyes as he drove in, cock pulsing and spilling pre cum into a marehood that sucked him in with every thrust. Christian grunted, eyes wide. What was going on? Celeste’s horn told him there was more afoot than he could understand. The unicorn cast him a reassuring glance – or as reassuring as she could be with her legs in the air – and he relaxed the best he could, taking his lead from fresh pleasure and pounding her with the force of ten stallions. The mare quivered beneath him, orgasm racing on her as he rubbed her clit in time with his thrusts, breath tight in his chest.

“Celeste!” He blurted, face screwed up. “I’m going...going to...”

“Spend yourself in me,” she managed to gasp out, holding her head as far up over her chest as she could in order to watch. “I desire...” Her words came with difficulty. “*You.*”

Ramming in to slap his balls against her rump, Christian let out a feral howl as he ejaculated, massive throbs of cum travelling up his magically enhanced member. As he spent himself inside her, his body juddered into her as if connected through an invisible string, pressing hard on her clit to send her into a whinnying climax a few seconds after he began the throes of his own. The unicorn kicked, barely missing his shoulder, and twisted on her back as pleasure wracked her, horn wildly shooting off sparks. For a second, he worried that his shaft would grow larger with her sudden outpouring of magic but, thankfully to him, it deflated with each spurt of cum, returning to its normal length and girth.

He pulled out, shocked by the lack of pleasure – how far could Celeste’s magic take him sexually? What could her magic do to their bodies? – and his shaft dropped, shiny with their combined sexual juices. Cum drooled from her marehood, viscously trickling over her swollen lips, passage slightly agape from recent penetration. Whickering as it oozed down over the flap of skin at the base of her tail, Celeste rolled on to her side and stretched out of head, tail lifted as if to better show off the creampie beneath it. Christian moaned softly and, on the spur of the moment, dipped his finger into the mess and licked it clean as he scooted up alongside his love. She tasted sweet like honey with something else combined – something beyond the hint of salty seed that was clearly his. Christian rested his head on her shoulder, cheek below her withers. Exhaustion lined his bones.

“It is only a shame that our mating will not produce a foal,” she whinnied, tucking Christian into the crook of her legs. “Unicorns may only...”

She sighed, resting her head on the cushions with her eyes lidded. Leaning back against her stomach, Christian relaxed, rubbing slow, soothing circles down her neck, as he imagined a

little dancing foal springing between her mother's legs, horn aglow with unrivalled magic. A family... He had never thought of having a family. But Celeste made him want things that had before seemed forever out of reach. Stroking her mane, he drifted towards sleep, cock flaccid at its normal size between his upper thighs.

"Perhaps we should have you transformed into a unicorn stallion, Christian." Celeste yawned, tail flicking. "Then I could bear your foal. We could build a family, together."

"Why not?" He said, afterglow clouding his mind. "I will always be your stallion, Celeste."

Celeste's head *shot* up from the cushions, eyes wide with a rim of white as she snorted, pushing her muzzle up to his face.

"You would do such a thing for me? Truly?"

Christian laughed lightly, not believing her serious.

"Of course, my love." He tucked a stray strand of forelock back into place, amused by her sudden animation. "I would do anything for you, absolutely anything."

The unicorn threw her head to the side and brought it back to his, touching her horn to his forehead. Its warmth seeped into him like water between rushes in a river and he started, treated in detail to what she imagined. He saw him as a stallion rearing at the crest of a hill, his mate standing tall beside him: Celeste. A foal darted between his legs, looking up at him with trusting, blue eyes and a tiny, fluffy tail that wagged as if she had spent too much time with a canine. Celeste moved the thought on, showing him a prosperous herd of unicorns with many foals playing together, thriving and continuing their line as unicorn-kind protected the forest. He saw her sire and dam, whom he was yet to meet, touching horns proudly with their daughter and him, thanking them for what they had done for the herd and all unicorns in the land.

His heart thudded, a low steady drone. Christian stared straight ahead as she lifted her horn away from his skull, breaking the transfer of thought. He could not even be impressed that her magic allowed such a thing to be possible.

Celeste had not spoken in pure wishes, dreaming of a future that could not be. He swallowed. Celeste could transform him into a stallion. She had plans to do so and had even *shown* him the spell that would allow it. He licked his lips and shook his head, lips moving but no words coming out.

As words flooded from the unicorn's lips, spinning tales of what their future together would be like, Christian could only nod, swept away by her excitement. Had he already agreed to her wishes? Was it too late to back out? Thinking of his life, the everyday monotony and uncertainty of the future, he was not even sure he wanted to. What would his mother think – his friends? Would they stand by him? Then again – would he truly be any different as a unicorn? He frowned. Friendships could cross a species barrier. He would still be Christian inside. He would only look a little different. Or very different.

His head hurt.

Stroking the unicorn's neck, he drifted into a restless sleep to the melody of her voice, wondering one thing alone as he lost his grip on reality.

What had he gotten himself into?

*

On his second visit to the unicorn village, or at least the outskirts, Christian, very fairly, he thought, found himself having, well, second thoughts. Turn him into a stallion? How could he ever have said such a thing? He didn't think Celeste was serious! Not at the time! What male could ever have been thinking sensibly after sex anyway?

And yet, here he was, sitting with his back against Celeste's shoulder in a glade beside a serene pond in the depths of the forest, waiting to announce the news to her parents. The pool rippled with lily pads, so large that Christian was tempted to see if they would support his weight and almost tested his balance on them if only for Celeste's amusement. Whether he managed to make his way completely across the pond with his clothes perfectly dry or plunged into the cooling depths, he was sure the unicorn would love to see him try. Her gaze on him spun his head giddy and he laughed and talked with her as the sun played high in the sky. They had the whole day to while away and even his worries could not chase his heels as he rested back into the unicorn's comforting warmth.

His cheek brushed the finery of her harness as her necklace, this time gold encrusted with rubies and opals that draped so far down that the largest pendant hung clean off her strong chest, tinkled musically. Her harness stretched all the way down her back and tucked beneath her croup, decorative and not restrictive while shimmering earrings hung from the base of her ears, lightly looped over each ear as if a headpiece. Sometimes he wondered if she adorned herself so in order to impress him, but had to remember that she was a princess after all. It could have been a tradition of their royalty for all he knew. And none of the gryphons they'd encounter before or any other creatures wore fine jewels, so unicorns must be the noblest of all magical creatures. He smiled. How silly of him. Even if unicorns were as solemn as donkeys, he would still consider Celeste the most beautiful lady in all the galaxies, let alone the world. Love tinted his view wondrously.

Celeste pricked her heads, turning her head from their conversation as soft hoof falls sounded through the trees, echoing through the ancient pines and birches to the willows by the water. A frog croaked and a pair of unicorns as silver-white as Celeste entered the secluded glade, the canopy of leaves above casting soft, shadowy dapples across their coats. The larger unicorn, a stallion, had a whiskery tuft of hair on his chin and Christian stifled a giggle, reminded of a wizened old man's beard. There was nothing aged about the unicorn, however, unless one counted the wisdom in his gaze, which had seen many seasons irrevocably pass by. His mate was shorter by about a hand – Christian's best guess – with a finer mane than fell over her neck like liquid silver, shimmering and floating over her coat with the slightest movement. Celeste nickered a welcome.

“Mother, father.”

Celeste rose, flinging out her forelegs to drag her body upright, touching her horn to that of her parent's in greeting. She nuzzled her mother's neck and shared breath, slowly exhaling as she relaxed in their presence.

"Christian." The stallion's voice rang crystalline and Christian surreptitiously swallowed, rubbing the back of his hand across his lips as he belatedly scrambled up. "It is a pleasure to meet the human who has so captured my daughter's heart. Why," he continued with a smile, "she has not stopped speaking of you since the day I presume you met."

"Father."

"Is it untrue, Celeste?" Her father teased, tail swishing as his mate snorted and shook her long forelock out of her eyes.

The unicorn grumbled and Christian pressed his hand over his lips, hiding a smile. He had never seen the unicorn look so abashed! And she'd been talking about him? His smile widened, crinkling in the corners of his eyes. It was strange to see her unicorn father behaving as any human father would, further cementing in his mind the similarities between them. Besides their form, natural elegance and magical abilities, there was little different between humans and unicorns when it came to mannerisms, behaviour and ideals.

So... Christian's brow furrowed. Would there truly be much difference between him as a unicorn or as a human? He would still be Christian and have all the same capabilities – more, if Celeste knew the truth of also being able to pass on the spark of magic to him too. No, not so strange at all then. Only a whole new body, nothing major. He could have laughed at himself and his futile attempt at reasoning.

Celeste dragged a hoof through the grass.

"If only it would not be a trait of family to embarrass you," she muttered, looking up through her mane. "Please, no more, I beg of you."

"What do you think, Christian?" The stallion chuckled lightly and stepped up to Christian, breathing warm air in his face in invitation to share breath. "Should I acquiesce to my daughter's wishes, or would you like to hear more?"

He froze, heart hammering. His mouth was too try to speak and he fumbled over words, opening and closing his mouth several times without any sound coming out.

"I think you should leave the poor colt alone," his mate reprimanded, swatting him with her tail. "Christian, please forgive my mate. I am Moirin and he, for all his jest, is Caderyn."

"It is a delight to meet you too," he stammered, cheeks burning as he tried to force his speech into a more formal style. "Celeste has also spoken of you, though I am learning much about the herd and your lives here."

Moirin nickered and reached out to touch his offered palm with the curve of her nose, mimicking a more casual equine greeting.

“Has Celeste shown you around the village yet? It must be an entirely different world for you here.”

He chuckled and nodded, slowly relaxing as he rested a hand on Celeste’s withers, idly playing with her mane.

“Very much so,” he agreed. “I don’t know if Celeste’s told you but I’m a student, just coming to the end of degree. The studying is complete now but I am waiting on results. I expected to be going to work next, not spending my time visiting a world that I didn’t even knew existed.”

He paused, conscious of his rambling, and flushed.

“I’m sorry, I don’t mean to go on. I just meant to show how vast the difference was,” he finished lamely, staring at his shoes.

“It is interesting, Christian,” Moirin said gently. “Unicorns listen. No member of the herd should ever feel isolated, so please continue speaking of your studies. We are impressed to find that Celeste has found herself a scholar, a worthy profession of yours indeed, if I understand human-kind correctly.”

The stallion tossed his head.

“A scholar!” Caderyn sounded impressed but it was harder to judge from his tone. “Celeste, you did not tell us of this.”

The unicorn shook herself, loose hair drifting from her coat to the grass where birds would later find it for their nests and young of another generation. As summer beckoned over the horizon, the heat bid her to shed a slightly thicker, though she had told him that unicorn magic mostly kept them warm through the colder months with the thicker coat remaining a leftover from their ancestors. Magic really was amazing, but that was self-explanatory.

Celeste lifted her head high and Christian took a breath, sensing that she was building up to something great. He curled his fingers around a strap of her jewellery harness and she shot him a quick yet reassuring glance: *I’m here*.

“Mother, father.” Celeste was swift to cut to the crux of the matter. “I have not solely brought you here today to introduce you to my mate.”

Although his heart sank at being referred to as her mate, Christian licked his lips and twisted his fingers together as they reached the point of no return. In all honesty, it had never felt as if he could say no to being transformed into a stallion with how excited Celeste was over it. He tried and tried to convince himself that it was the right thing to do and he could not even for the life of him come up with any solid reasons for staying human when the option to be otherwise was presented to him. His family and friends would still be there for him and it was those non-material relationships that meant the most to him.

Now, however, there would be no going back from revealing the secret and he braced himself, calves tensing as if balanced on the precipice of a cliff. He teetered and plunged over the edge as Celeste made her proclamation.

“There is no way for me to say this aloud that expresses the gravity of our decision without sharing thoughts.” Celeste stamped, horn flashing in a shaft of sunlight. “Yet I wish for Christian to hear this too. He is a part of this even more so than I am.”

Her father stretched out his head towards her, nickering concern as his expression clouded over, lips reaching for his daughter.

“What is it Celeste?” Caderyn queried, words quicker in his haste. “Are you unwell?”

“No, no,” she assured him swiftly. “We merely have news. Great news for the herd.”

She inhaled slowly, taking her time.

“Christian has agreed to allow me to transform him into a stallion. A unicorn stallion.”

They were silent, only their tails moving as they digested the information over the course of several seconds. And then they exploded into movement, Caderyn lifting himself up on to his hind legs to paw excitedly at the air, sides twitching as muscle refused to lay still below his skin.

“A stallion!” He neighed, treating Christian to a rather explicit view at close quarters of what exactly made him a stallion. “Celeste, Christian – in all my years, never has anyone surprised me with a delight as great as this!”

“But Celeste!” Her mother threw her head back and swung it into Caderyn, pushing his shoulder, with a squeal. “This is wonderful news! Another stallion for the herd! Our line shall continue!”

“It is most excellent news,” Caderyn agreed, dropping back to all fours and stepping in closer to them. “However did you come to this decision?”

Christian fought with himself not to back away, his space crowded by unicorns on all sides, leaning in to demand his attention. His mare pranced on the spot, foam lightly flecking her lips as she performed a near perfect example of piaffe, if his recently gained equine knowledge was up to par.

“It shall be wonderful,” Celeste proclaimed. “He will become a stallion and our foals will strengthen the herd. Perhaps we shall even have more stallions for the herd. And we shall search for ways to ensure unicorns survive.” Her eyes hardened. “No more of this fear that one day we shall be no more. It is time for a new age, one that we shall bring forth!”

“Yes, but how did you come to this decision?” Her mother prompted gently.

“We were merely talking and it is a shame that humans and unicorns cannot breed as unicorn and unicorn would,” Celeste explained, albeit vaguely. “It seems like the only rational decision at this point.”

Pausing, she dropped her head to nuzzle Christian’s cheek and he smiled, returning her caress with the brush of his lips. Her touch soothed him, expressing the love held in his heart.

“And I love him,” she said softly. “And he loves me. Our souls are meant to be together.”

Leaning into her, Christian closed his eyes as her parents murmured to her, losing himself as their conversation bubbled above his head. That was the centre of it, it had to be. There could be nothing else, nothing more, if he was not with his love and she with him. If he could be with Celeste, nothing was too great a sacrifice. He could do something with his life. He could spend his life with *Celeste*.

Her words lulled him into a sense of calm, rocking back and forth with the gentle sway of her body as she adjusted her weight, not needing to chime in with any words as she took care of the conversation for him. And perhaps that was all he needed. For so long had he struggled against the flow – for what reason? With the unicorns, he could be confident in all he was doing for a greater good and a love that encompassed his entire being.

The unicorn’s stream of conversation trailed off and she exhaled a breath as if she had held it for a time, her large sides heaving outward.

“If you’d forgive me, mother, father...” Celeste bowed her head and Christian was startled to see a line of shyness enter the angle of her body as she half-turned away. “I would like to spend time with my mate now. I will join you for the evening meal, as we planned.”

“Of course,” Moirin replied smoothly, ushering her mate away even as he neighed his protests, a million questions on his lips. “We understand your reason, Celeste. You must undoubtedly wish to talk. We shall leave you to enjoy the afternoon. And, Christian,” she added, inclining her head gracefully. “Thank you.”

“Yes... Thank you, Christian,” Caderyn whinnied back as he was playfully ‘bullied’ away, Moirin teasing him for being so easily pushed around by a smaller unicorn like herself. “I am confident we shall speak again soon.”

Shaking his head, Christian laughed quietly and lifted his hand to wave as they disappeared into the trees, light-hearted nickers bouncing back and forth long after they had vanished from sight.

“They’re different from what I expected,” Christian commented.

“Is anything as you expect, Christian?” The unicorn giggled, tail loose and relaxed against her rump. “It is a sentence that you seem to repeat with excessive frequency.”

He shoved her lightly in the ribs, grinning at her indignant squeal.

“Oh, I do, do I?” He gave as good as he got. “Maybe I’ll call your parents back – I’m sure they have some more funny stories about you.” He grinned, stepping back as her head shot up. “Should I do that Celeste? How *cute* were you as a foal? Shall I give them a call and join you for evening-meal?”

“You would not!”

Squealing, the unicorn threw a sideways buck out of sheer joy and chased Christian around the pond, shrieking wicked ‘insults’ that had him laughing so hard his ribs ached all the way. The unicorn finally caught him, blunt teeth yanking on his jacket, and she toppled him to the ground, thrusting her muzzle hotly into his face as if thrilled with her prize. She harried him, pawing gently with her front hooves until Christian begged her to stop, rolling back and forth on the sweet, soft grass with his arms wrapped around his torso. The tension held in his shoulders slipped away like water down an embankment and he sighed happily, sprawling as Celeste trotted down to the pond with a flirty flick of her tail, making sure he had a good view of her marehood. His cock stirred. She was already eager and winking, as ready as ever.

As Celeste lowered her muzzle to the pool to drink, Christian’s mind wandered. Why would the mare choose him when she could have her pick of stallions? Not that he was not grateful for it, it only made no sense at all.

“Celeste,” he began, hesitating with half his nerve before he could complete the utterance. “I was wondering...”

The mare turned to him, eyes curious as she dipped her head in close to his, chin dripping lightly with droplets of water. Gulping, he tried to moisten his mouth with saliva that was not forthcoming, instead joining the mare by the edge of the water and scooping up a pouring mouthful of aqua vitae between his hands.

“Yes, Christian?”

He struggled for words, tongue tied in a thousand knots.

“Why me?” He said at last, unable to hold her gaze. “You hardly know me. Why have you chosen me over everyone else? There are stallions in the herd and you’re the princess...” His lips twisted. “You could be with anyone you desired.”

Celeste took a step back, head high and nostrils flared as if he had startled her. She snorted and turned her head from left to right, searching for the humour in his joke and finding none.

“Christian...” It was Celeste’s turn to be lost for words. “If I did not have you, my life would go on but the meaning would be lost. Like the daffodils of spring appearing after a long, hard winter, my life has flourished since you have come into it, blossoming like those flowers, my favourite flowers. Summer has come and you are my season.”

The unicorn shuddered as if holding something back, a secret that words could not reveal.

“It feels superfluous to say this also,” she continued. “Yet you are willing to give up your whole life for me, Christian, to be with me and come to the aid of unicorn-kind. I cannot think of any unicorn that may endeavour to support another with an equal level of commitment.”

She pushed her muzzle into his chest and held it there as his arms encircled her head, holding her close with the tip of her horn tickling the underside of his chin. Even though his heart beat somehow erratically, he held his tongue, simply listening.

“We have only been mates for a short time, Christian, and yet you still want to do this for me.”

Christian curled his fingers into her mane, frizzing it up in his clutch yet wanting to hold on to the mare for life itself. Lowering his forehead to her horn, he fell into her mind as if down the rabbit hole to another world, seeing what she saw in what she envisaged for them. He saw them, both unicorns, galloping over hill and down valleys, hooves kicking up water as they crossed mountain streams. Nothing barred them from their path, their destiny.

Christian dove deeper, swimming through the unicorns conscious stream of thought to pick out the details with greatest colour. A foal. A foal reappeared, hooves silver and the light of a thousand suns in his eyes. A colt, a little colt. Christian gasped, seeing her protection and love for her home shining through all like a beacon, passion growing with every day that passed, all with him by her side. Her dreams did not lack founding and her love for him, so powerful that he fought not to step back a pace from the force of it, twined around everything, a fruitful vine that empowered all it touched.

“It is I who should be thanking you for making such a great sacrifice.” She lifted her horn away, breaking the connection, and pressed her lips to his in a kiss, tongues dancing. “It is more than I should ever have asked of you.”

He kissed her deeply, as if it was the last kiss they would ever share. His fingers dug into her coat and she trembled, frozen under the weight of what they were about to do. Greater than either of them had ever known, they could embark on their journey side by side, hand in hoof. Later, hoof in hoof.

If his princess would protect him, he would always be there for her. Christian kissed her nose, hands cupping the curve of her dished cheeks.

“Celeste, I would do anything for you.”

*

A circle of unicorns ringed Christian, horns tilted in towards him. Celeste stood at his side, so close that her foreleg and shoulder brushed the length of his body. Snorting, she eased her body closer still, unwilling to let him move away for even the fraction of a second. Resting a hand on her shoulder, as he wouldn't have a hand for much longer, he murmured softly to her, watching her ears flick towards him in response.

His whole life was about to change and it felt like any other normal day. The birds sang through the trees above the unicorn village, branches outstretched as if in protection, and deer grazed between the trees, does watchful over their fawns. He watched as a stag chewed a mouthful of gaze, jaw working in a circular motion to crush it down, forced down his throat by a slimy, grey tongue.

The unicorn had worn a special array of jewellery for the occasion. With fabric base to contain the precious gems, the unicorn wore a loop of silk around the base of her neck, which dipped down between her forelegs and met back at her withers. The silk was dotted in a pattern pleasing to the eye with snowflake obsidian, black stones with a smatter of grey-white across each tumbled stone, shiny under the weight of their care. A head piece draped down

from her ears, hanging loose over her cheekbones and down the centre of her face in like stones, woven so that it required no fastenings to stay in place no matter how much she moved her head. Around her fetlocks looped further beads and beads of obsidian and moonstone, complementing one another. Finally, her tail and mane boasted the stones woven in so that they appeared to sprout from the hairs themselves, a part of her as she had grown. Christian struggled to drag his eyes away from her. The mare looked as if she had stepped straight out of a fairytale. And his fairytale was about to begin.

“Christian,” Celeste’s father approached him, meeting his eyes – a mark of respect. “Are you prepared for the ceremony?”

Christian was not sure how he should have prepared but he knew in his heart that he was as ready as he would ever be.

“I am, sir.”

Caderyn touched Christian on either shoulder with the tip of his horn. The human quivered under the force of the magic roiling within, more powerful than even Celeste’s. But his daughter was younger and less experienced than the aged, wizened stallion. One day, she would be as strong as he.

“You will do well,” he said, tone grave and eyes serious. “Thank you, Christian, for the sacrifice you are about to make.”

Moirin joined her mate in the centre of the circle as the gathered unicorns shuffled, excitement running through the herd as one. The mare lifted her head high and whinnied to the twilight sky above, the first stars dotting the grey-blue visible between the leaves.

“Brothers! Sisters! We are gathered here today to bear witness to the transformation of Christian, a human, into a unicorn.”

She paused, ears pricked. The unicorns stamped and cheered, colours blending together as much as their differences set them apart. The herd was stronger together yet they were all unique. Moirin held her head high.

“In doing so, he shall join our cause in securing the future of unicorns across the world, ensuring that our line continues and strengthens with his blood!”

Kneeling, Christian bowed his head to a chorus of unicorn nickers, letting the sound surround him and lift him up. He could do it. He would do it. For the herd – his herd. For Celeste. His heart beat steadily and he took deep, calming breaths, picking out the details in the grass beneath his hands. He spread his fingers around the blades, watching a red ladybird with three black spots on each wing crawl to the tip of a single stem like a drop of dew.

Whinnying, Celeste ducked her head to nuzzled his shoulder and he lifted his hand to her, letting her push her nose into his palm. He wouldn’t have a palm for much longer so he may as well have some use of it. He only wished he could use his fingers to pleasure her one last time.

The unicorn king and queen stepped back, allowing them their space for the ceremony. Looking up, Christian met Celeste's trusting, peaceful gaze and nodded just the once: he was ready.

"How should we begin?" He asked, careful to keep the tremor out of his voice. "I...I wouldn't know how this is done. But you do."

"The transformation is simple," she assured him with a toss of her head. "It only requires a willing participant. The unwilling do not have the heart to be transformed and, if a forced transformation is attempted, it will simply fail. Have faith, Christian."

She hesitated, turning her head to the side with an unexpectedly coy look. Her mane had been braided – undoubtedly with magic – and her plaited forelock fell as straight as an arrow down between her eyes.

"Perhaps there is one detail that I have kept close to myself," she said, eyes alight with mischief. "I wished it to be a surprise, Christian."

He laughed, relieved for the humour as clumps of hair stuck to the back of his neck, soaked with sweat.

"Another surprise? I think I could do without those today, my love. What have you been keeping from me?"

"Stay still."

Stepping over him, Celeste angled her body so that Christian kneeled face to face with her udders – still formed of two pairs. She had remembered that he liked them and kept the look for him. He blushed to be presented with such an intimate area in front of a keenly observant audience. It seemed to him that not single unicorn breathed as he looked from left to right, stymied for what he was supposed to do. He stroked the underside of Celeste's stomach from between her forelegs to her udders, his smallest finger just barely grazing them. Celeste snorted, one hind hoof stamping in the soft grass.

"Unicorn milk is potent," she murmured, tail flagged eagerly. "For the transformation, it serves as a vessel for my magic. All you need to do is drink from my udders and it shall be done. It is I who shall take care of the rest."

Christian shook his head and sat back on his heels. That was too sexual! Of course, it was all a foal would do at the hoof of their dam but he wasn't a foal. He was mature and anything there... His blush intensified, creeping down his neck over the hint of black stubble. No. It couldn't be done. Not in front of an audience.

He was about to tell Celeste exactly that, that they would have to go somewhere more private despite the flicker of excitement in his stomach, when she nickered more urgently, muscle twitching as if agitated.

"I do not mean to place you on display, Christian – I know what's going through your mind, I know you. We are unicorns, it will not be obscene." She craned her neck around to barely

brush the back of his head at the side of her stomach, unwilling to move. “Please, Christian. I need you.”

He had never before heard an edge of pleading enter her tone, which was low enough that only he could hear. But it was that gleam of desperation and love that nudged him into action. He would be brave for her. And it was not as if being on show did not give him a slow, burning thrill. Maybe he’d have to explore that particular notion a little later. Celeste was far from shy to show him off!

Lifting his fingers to his lips one last time, he blew her a kiss, a smile on his lips.

“I love you.”

He didn’t give her the chance to reply before he leaned in, latching his lips around her nearest teat and taking the another between his fingers. As he suckled, searching for her sweetness, he rolled and massaged her udders in both hands, leaving no spot untouched as the unicorn whinnied and snorted above him. He smiled mentally to think of her marehood winking, clit exposed and bulging, as she grew aroused, demanding to be mounted by her stallion.

Her milk poured thickly into his mouth and he moaned, eyes closed as he absorbed himself in the taste. As pure as honey, it possessed the potency of the finest liquor, an addiction in its very essence. He squeezed her soft udders gently in his hands, coaxing more of the treat from them, and found himself adapting his sucks to better draw milk from her. Flicking his tongue over her teat, he flushed pleasurably to hear her breathing growing laboured, sides heaving and darkening with sweat. The heat of her body and concentration it took to perform the spell commanded everything her body had to offer her.

The change began so gradually that he barely noticed it at first. Something deep inside tingled and, at first, he believed himself to merely be becoming aroused. Indeed – his cock was hardening but that was not the only difference in his body. As the unicorns looked on wisely, a light prickle of grey-white hair sprouted all over his body, the hair atop his head whitening to a silvery sheen. Warmth spread through his body from his lips down to his toes, stimulated by the milk, and he swapped to another of Celeste’s teats, opening his eyes to see an aquamarine aura of magic surrounding him and the mare as if they had been encased within a blue bubble.

Christian groaned as the warmth turned to heat and he sucked harder, using Celeste as an anchor as he curled his fingers around the canon bone of her hind right leg. Yet his fingers were thick and clumsy and he could not hold on, hand dropping back to the grass as a high-pitched whine burst from his nostrils, eerily like the first call of a foal. It was more and more difficult to stay in position beneath the mare as his bones shifted and lengthened beneath his skin, their movement not particularly pleasant. He could not have said that it was painful, however, having nothing to compare it with.

Focusing on the physical sensations so much, Christian took a moment to notice a mane growing and spilling down his stretching neck, forelock falling over his eyes so that his world became silvery. He grew larger, spine elongating with a series of pops that made his eyes bulge, a tickle at the base of it denoting a tail sprouting in time with his mane. It flicked, the new protrusion oddly limber as he twitched it back and forth. Dimly, as if from a great

distance, he heard a unicorn that was not Celeste neigh as if to encourage. Was he halfway there?

His cock throbbed and he *had* to turn his head, releasing the teat, just to see what it looked like. It transformed before his eyes, swelling with every throb as pre cum drooled from the tip, spreading into a flatter, mushroom shape than his human length. The skin turned a mottled grey and pink, balls rounding out and hanging more heavily between his thighs – no. He caught himself. They were his hind legs now. He didn't have thighs like he'd had what seemed to be only a few heartbeats earlier.

How long was the transformation taking? One minute? One hour? Time lost meaning as Celeste poured greater and greater amounts of magic into his body, neck arched from the strain of it. His arms crackled, shoulders shifting into a new position as his fingers melded together and hardened into hooves to match Celeste's with the appearance that they had been dipped in silver. He planted them on the grass experimentally, finding them to hold, and let them bear his weight as his half-formed forelegs bent beneath him, knees on the grass and fetlocks tucked under his stomach. His belly rounded out and out and out and he took a deep breath, feeling a pair of much larger lungs expand, no longer needing to take breaths as frequently as he had as a human. It only cemented the change in him and he exhaled slowly, satisfied that there would be no turning back.

Christian's hindquarters dropped clumsily to the ground as his body changed, cock slapping his belly, refusing to soften. Strings of pre cum, translucent white, strung down to the grass to pool there and would have stained his coat if it had not already become a perfect, snowy white, as pure as Celeste's. His heart swelled and he groaned as his face protruded more and more, eyes sliding to either side of his head. His lips were too big to easily grip her teat but he tried anyway, lipping over each of her udders in turn as the mare nickered and jiggled one front hoof in the air.

The new stallion lay as if a newborn foal with his hind legs tucked to one side, beautiful neck arched up to the mare's teats as if to take an offering kindly presented. His forehead throbbed lightly, warmth cooling from the remainder of his body, as a solitary silver horn rose elegantly from the centre of his forehead, bumping into Celeste's flank as he tilted his head to the side. Christian sucked, ears slipping back to his skull in concentration, cock slapping up to his belly, stimulated by muscles he had never fathomed stallions could control.

"Christian."

His eyes were still closed, intent on his task. He couldn't stop! He had to complete the transformation. He had to keep sucking. Celeste wanted him to, he had to continue.

"*Christian.*"

Celeste stepped away and nuzzled the top of his head between a pair of pointed ears.

"It is done."

He opened his eyes and pulled his head back, smacking his horn straight into Celeste's side. Though she winced, the unicorn made no complaint as she carefully took two steps back,

allowing Christian space in which to gather his bearings. She smiled warmly, looking him over as if pleased with her work, head high in greeting.

“Welcome home, Christian.”

The herd joined her, erupting into a melody of neighs and whinnies as Christian boldly dragged his legs beneath him and scrambled to his hooves for the first time as a stallion. The world bobbed and swayed as he splayed his legs for balance, head dropped low to the ground as if that would allow him something to act as a weight, keeping him upright. Celeste pressed up to his side, supporting him with her body as she touched her cheek to his. Her horn still emanated a lyrical glow and, though a line of exhaustion ran through her body, it was all she could do to not prance back and forth like a filly with her sweetheart colt.

A typical, sweet male, once he had his balance, Christian twisted his head round to check out his stallion parts, eyes as wide as a unicorn could make them. His cock hung proudly beneath his stomach, balls as round as a pair of grapefruit – larger, even. He nickered and bobbed his muzzle, straining for a better look as Celeste giggled lightly, relief colouring her tone. Perhaps she had been more concerned about his transformation than he had. But there was no longer any reason to worry, not for either of them.

“Those seem...larger than I expected,” Christian said, trying out his new lips and muzzle.

Words did not come as smoothly as they had as a human but he thought he would quickly get used to the feel, rolling words around a mouth and tongue that had not initially been designed for speech.

“I thought you may enjoy the appearance,” Celeste commented, eyes twinkling. “Until your magic develops, it shall be my pleasure to mould this new body as you will, Christian. Consider it my gift to you.” She paused, head tilted as if considering something. “Magic, however, must come to you naturally. It is not a swift gift to be given.”

“I’m sure I can work with that.”

Magic? That was new. He felt it throbbing in his horn, yet it was somehow beyond his reach. No matter: that was something that could be handled another day.

Celeste turned, presenting him with her rump and flicked her tail high, showing off her pink marehood, already flushed and puffy. Her hind legs spread, bracing herself as she nickered encouragement, ignorant to her audience as her folds twitched, enticing him in. The stallion’s cock flexed and he shook his head, mane flopping back and forth from either side of his neck.

“Celeste!” He hissed, though it came out with a higher pitch than expected, more of a whinny than a hiss. “What are you doing? Here?”

He fumbled with his words, watching with his lower jaw slack as the unicorn mare steadied herself and urinated in a splash of fluid, demonstrating her need and readiness without words passing the air between them. She pushed her tail to the side as the stream tapered off, leaving her swollen clit and clenching marehood to draw him in. Out of his sight, the mare smiled, nostrils flaring in a snort. Feminine wiles would always work on a stallion.

“Do you not wish to make use of your body, Christian?” She nickered, marehood winking and dripping with arousal. “I had thought you would as eager as a colt to feel what it means to be a stallion in need.”

He couldn't – not with all the other unicorns watching! And yet... He glanced around, ears drooping uncertainly to either side of his head without conscious thought. They seemed to move in accordance to his mood and words, an extension of communication that he had not been blessed enough to understand as a human. The other unicorns – even Celeste's parents – encouraged him with nickers and snorts, stamping and pawing the air as if keen to see him use his new form in the most primal and physical of ways. For, to them, there was no greater way in which a unicorn may express love and magic than the bonding of two bodies as one. With unicorns, there was no shame.

Christian snorted and half-reared, forelegs nearly straight as he wove back and forth, head bobbing and swaying in time with his body. His cock was ready and drooling, needing no stimulation to please his mare, his sweetheart, his princess. Unsteadily lifting himself up on to his hind legs, he dropped as lightly as possible on to her back and shuffled in closer, cock jabbing. For a moment, he feared that he would hurt her with his weight but the mare merely groaned and pushed back, easily strong enough to support him. Jabbing randomly with his cock, he sought her entrance with a low, throaty nicker.

His entrance was not as smooth as their previous copulations had been, Christian easily able to see where to slide his cock in with a mare so much bigger than he. The flat head of his shaft pushed against her rump and slid slickly over her white coat, leaving trails of glimmering pre cum in its wake. She whinnied, demanding pleasure, and he grunted, scooting in a step closer and pressing the tip into Celeste's tight folds.

The stallion groaned. She was even tighter than before, clenching and squeezing around his thicker length, sucking him in as he thrust lightly, feeling out his own body. His shaft slid with a wet slurp and he bucked forward instinctively, the urge greater than his mind trying to make sense of the motion. Gripping Celeste's flanks with his forelegs, he rocked into her, spearing deep enough that the head of his cock forced its way up almost to her cervix, so close to bottoming out inside her. Dimly – his mind was clouded with other more immediate needs – he hoped she would use her magic the next time to make him larger still and better able to please her. It was all he wished for.

Thrusting into the eagerly shifting mare beneath him, Christian drove onwards, plunging in with greater force as his boldness grew. His only regret in his form was that he no longer was able to rub and stroke her clit, pushing her towards climax, as he had in their very first session and every mating since. Hey, maybe his magic would later be strong enough for him to tease her body as she had transformed him. He would make it work, somehow, as his hands once had.

But he was now a stallion. A shiver rippled through him from shoulder to flank as he thrust, pace increasing in short, sharp thrusts, barely pulling his cock back at all before slamming in again with the full force of his body. Celeste adored every second of it if her soft grunts and light tremors were anything to go by, his flaring cock hitting pleasurable spots deep inside that no human cock, even magically enhanced, ever could. While a human could not sire a foal, a stallion certainly could.

The thought of a foal dancing around his hooves, everything they had dreamed of, drove him over the edge, chest rumbling with a groan as he pounded her tight marehood. She suddenly threw her head back and whinnied shrilly, rocking so fiercely that she nearly bucked him off, her stallion having sent her into orgasmic throes, body no longer her own as pleasure claimed it. Spurred on, Christian ploughed her with passion, tail slowly flagging as he reached his own peak and drew out her own until the mare nickered helplessly beneath him, vulnerable to the sways of ecstasy.

Climax whipped about the stallion with the force of a storm crashing upon a forest in the dead of night, taking the silent and stirring every stick from the peaty floor. His cock throbbed, heavy ropes of cum shooting from the head to paint the mare's cunny, splattering up against her cervix in a warm heat. Though not something a female would usually feel in the heat of the moment, Celeste dipped her head and moaned, so intimately connected to her stallion lover that each and every moment of their mating was enhanced by her magic into explicit, glorious detail. She felt every twitch of his shaft within her, softening ever so slightly as the stallion spent himself to exhaustion, weight heavier upon her. To Christian, it was better than he ever could have imagined, to have his first time as a stallion.

Dismounting from his mare, he landed with a thud back on all four hooves, having yet to learn the art of elegance. Caderyn stepped up to touch his horn to Christian's as the stallion composed himself, the unicorn king evidently comfortable with what he had witnessed, though there was a wise yet wicked gleam in his eye. His mate brushed her muzzle over his withers, lips briefly working in a companionship groom, lipping the base of his mane as she snorted softly. The mare's horn exuded wafting, pink waves of magic as she touched her cheek to Caderyn's.

"We welcome you as one of us, Christian." Celeste's father dipped his horn to the ground, past the point where it would have been a threat pointed at his chest. "We hope you will find your happiness among us."

With the mating complete and transformation sealed, the unicorn king and queen respectfully took their leave, leaning their bodies in close to one another as they left. Christian suspected one would find them in their bedchambers, enjoying their bodies, before the night was out. And why should they not? His heart warmed, orgasm making his eyelids droop even as a stallion. Some things never changed. And love was one thing that he hoped would remain as it was forever, only growing stronger with each passing day.

He turned to Celeste, ears flicking. What next? Her front hooves lifted from the ground in a filly-like rear, head twisting as she tossed it, balancing perfectly on her hind hooves. Spinning in a tight circle, she nickered and nipped her lover's neck playfully, daring him to play. The circle of unicorns broke and dispersed with many a congratulations as the lovers danced and played, teasing each other with flagged tails and fleeting touches that made the other crave more and more.

Eventually, sides heaving, Celeste skidded to a stop in the turf, hooves digging up clumps of grass in her abrupt halt. She turned to Christian and brushed her lips down his face from his cheek to his nose in an equine kiss, lips touching and tongues sharing an intimate moment. It was clumsier but all the sweeter for it without his human lips to shape to hers and Christian huffed gently into the kiss, sidling his body in closer. When the kiss broke, Celeste exhaled softly, breath blowing over his muzzle.

“We have much to do.”

Somehow, he didn't think her body wanted the same thing as her mind, in the moment, marehood winking as she half-turned, mind moving on to matters of unicorn-kind befitting a princess. Nickered, Christian rested his chin on her rump, nostrils flaring. She swatted him in the face with her tail and threw a light buck his way – all in play.

“Oh, if you must,” she laughed, pirouetting as her lover chased her tail, fumbling over his new hooves in the tighter turn, needing more space in which to control himself. “But then we must return to my home – our home! We must rest to complete our duties in the morning. The sun will not set slower for us.”

She dipped her head to touch her horn to his and Christian trembled, shaft slipping eagerly from its sheath once again. It did not feel as if it had ever become truly soft since he had been transformed. Celeste whinnied and he reached for her with magic in lieu of touch, their separate powers interlocking like the fingers of two lovers. She blew warm air into his muzzle and the new unicorn's heart sang as his lover looked deep into his eyes. Duties could come later. For now, they had each other.

“We have time for one more mating.”

Pushing his nose under Celeste's tail as the mare winked and flagged for him, marehood clenching in as if denying him entrance and then spreading as wide as her muscles allowed once more. Tracing his tongue over her swollen, pink lips, shining with their juices, he tasted her honey and his salt, thicker and more potent. In his mind, there could only be a foal stirring in her belly now and the thought made his chest puff out mentally, proud of what he had been bold enough to achieve. He was more as a unicorn than he had ever been as a human.

His cock struck home and slid in deep to a chorus of his mare's nickers. And he was as much, if not more, her stallion as she was his mare. Together, they were stronger. Christian grunted as he drove in deep, tail flagged boldly.

Life as a stallion was going to be magnificent!